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**Padmabhushan
Dr. Nageshwar Reddy**
Founder & Chairman, AIG Hospitals

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Mr. Manni Kantipudi – CEO

ARAGEN

In Every molecule is the possibility for better health

CAN YOU PLEASE GIVE AN OVERVIEW OF YOUR PROFESSIONAL BACKGROUND LEADING UP TO AND INCLUDING YOUR CURRENT ROLE?

My journey with Aragen (formerly, GVK BIO) started way back in 2007. I joined as the President and then became the Director and CEO in 2009. Over the years, the company has emerged as a leading R&D and manufacturing solutions provider to the global life sciences industry. During this tenure, Aragen Biosciences (based out of CA, USA) was acquired in 2014 to expand service offerings for large molecules. We were probably the first Indian CRO to make an overseas acquisition as a part of our inorganic growth. In my current role, I am responsible for the overall growth, providing strategic direction and shaping the culture of the company.

WHAT HAVE BEEN SOME OF THE SIGNIFICANT HIGHLIGHTS OF ARAGEN LIFE SCIENCES HISTORY?

Our journey over the last two decades has been a journey demonstrating our consistent growth, our continued transformation to meet our customer's ever growing needs. We started as an informatics company in 2001. Ever since then, we have brought in diverse range of capabilities /capacities in chemistry, biology, process development, manufacturing, formulation development and analytical services to become an end-to-end integrated discovery-development-



manufacturing solutions partner to our customers. From a single site operation in Hyderabad, we now operate out of seven locations (including one in US). To reach out to our customers, we now have a global BD team situated out of US, EU and Japan. We are now recognized as one of the market leaders from Asia and this is a testimony to the team that we have assiduously built over the years. Our acquisition of Aragen Biosciences in 2014, enabled us to expand our discovery and development service offerings from small molecules to biologics too.

During this time, we have also been able to attract some of the best investors - Sequoia Capital and ChrysCapital who have been very satisfied and rewarded with their investment and association with us. Our current investor - Goldman Sachs brings worldwide network and experience that will help expand Aragen's portfolio of differentiated offerings and client base to accelerate the company's growth. We have been recognized and accredited by leading regulatory agencies like US FDA, AAALAC reflecting our industry leading practices and systems in

place. We are also one of the few CROs who have been recognized twice as 'Great Place to Work', won Asia's best employer brand award and Best-of-Breed COVID Champion Award from National HR Development Network. the best places to work

WHAT ARE SOME OF ARAGEN LIFE SCIENCES'S KEY VALUES AND BELIEFS? HOW IMPORTANT IS CUSTOMER'S SATISFACTION?

Very much aligned to our purpose- In every molecule is the possibility for better health, the customer has always been the universe around which we operate. Whether large Pharma or small biotech, small or large molecule, our empowered teams give equal importance to every project. The values we offer at Aragen is with the vision of accelerating our customer's pathway to success.

WHAT DO YOU THINK SETS YOUR BUSINESS APART FROM ITS COMPETITORS?

Our differentiator have been the ability to implement our thoughts into actions to benefit all our stakeholders – customers, employees, investors and the ecosystem that we operate in. These are outlined below.

Customer at the Center - We give complete attention to each customer, offering a reliable and seamless experience.

Agile Partnerships - Every drug program is different and customers require agility and adaptiveness. We meet this challenge through responsive customer service, quick-to-adapt solutions, enabling technologies, and a partnership approach to every engagement.

Innovation Mindset & Empowered Teams - Leveraging our innovation mindset, rich scientific talent and empowered teams, we consistently deliver value to our customers.

Technology-enabled Platform & Operational Excellence - Our proprietary technologies and operational efficiencies compress

development timelines, offer a secure and seamless experience, and accelerate speed to market of customer products.

Concept to Commercial - We are end-to-end, full service partners to our customers, offering scalable and flexible solutions along the bio pharma value chain.

Corporate Sustainability: let us include a few lines here)

Our new brand mark embodies the brand promise, Together Ahead. We believe in collaborative partnerships and transparency. We collaborate and not compete. What we do is transparent business without any competing interest with any of our customers. We are not affiliated to any pharma companies nor do we invest in assets nor in equity of our partners. Our philosophy has been clear from the start and this value is what sets us apart from the rest.

HOW HAVE YOU FOUND THE BIO INDUSTRY IN INDIA?

With significant capital flowing into life sciences industry, every company, whether a large pharma or a young biotech, all have externalization as key element of their core growth plan. In 2020 alone, the industry attracted over \$23B in venture investments. These new firms all need CRO services. Especially with the recent trade wars and India having cost advantages, we can expect it to be the beneficiary of such capital trends.

HOW IMPORTANT IS CULTURE TO THE BUSINESS? HOW DO YOU INSTILL THIS IN YOUR EMPLOYEES?

Aragen's core values that are abbreviated as ETHICS guide our decisions, express our beliefs and define our culture. These are deeply embedded in our DNA that we live by every day. It is what determines 'how we do what we do' to our customers.

E- Empowerment: Employees are given the freedom to make a difference

T – Team Work: We function as agile, cross-functional teams focused on addressing customer problems and accelerating solutions

H - Honesty & Integrity: We are mindful of our role in the global bio-Pharma ecosystem and fully aware of our responsibility in providing reliable, consistent and quality data to accelerate the programs of our customers

I – Innovation: It is about developing solutions that are more effective and commercially relevant

C – Customer Focus: By providing flexible, integrated, end-to-end services along the concept-to-commercial continuum, we give our customers effective and timely solutions. Our customer repeat rate of over 90% is a reflection of our relentless focus on customer centricity.

S-Safety & Compliance: 'Safety and Compliance Always' is a way of life at Aragen.

Regular reviews, training, seminars, and implementation of technologies, demonstrate our commitment to embedding and continuously improving company-wide safety and compliance.

WHAT ARE THE PLANS FOR THE FUTURE IN TERMS OF EXPANSION AND GROWTH?

Over time, we have emerged as a global leader and partner of choice in small molecule discovery. We are rapidly expanding on small molecule development and manufacturing.

In large molecules, we are known for Cell Line Development where we help our partners succeed in expression of the most challenging proteins. We will continue to invest discovery footprint both in Hyderabad and Bangalore, we see clearly that the discovery needs are growing rapidly. In Development and manufacturing, we recently invested significantly in expansions, and now have the capacity to meet our customer's immediate future needs. In Biologics, we are



advancing downstream, and investing in a manufacturing facility in the US to offer a single seamless solution to our customers that want to develop and manufacture, all at one place

WHAT STRATEGIES DOES ARAGEN LIFE SCIENCES HAVE IN PLACE TO IMPROVE YOUR SUPPLY CHAIN AND BUILD LONG TERM RELATIONSHIPS WITH KEY PARTNERS?

Being part of service industry, our supply chain needs to be highly responsive towards business requirements and it's also critical to maintain profitability as well as focus on sustainability. Project based solutions requires to have long term forecast or standard BOQ/ MRP. Sometimes, this creates challenges to have long term contract or advanced planning. some of the key pillars to drive high performance in supply chain are technology adaption, continuous performance improvement, robust processes, supply risk mitigation, techno commercial resources, reliable/ effective supply partner base and industry benchmarking.

WHAT ARE SOME OF THE KEY GOALS MR. MANNI KANTIPUDI AND ARAGEN LIFE SCIENCES COMPANY HAVE ACHIEVED SINCE THEY BEGAN THEIR ROLE AS THE CEO?

The Year 2021 is a defining milestone on our journey so far. It marks the 20th anniversary of GVK BIO's resilient growth story and its transformation into Aragen, a trusted R&D and manufacturing partner to the global life sciences industry. We have come a long way from where we started as an informatics company to Sequoia Capital investing in the company acquiring Aragen Bioscience in the U.S, we have had rapid expansions. In 2014, we established the second R&D facility at Mallapur. The year 2016 was significant for us in the sense that we expanded rapidly by starting a vivarium in Morgan Hill, CA and third R&D campus at Bangalore, India. The same year, we welcomed ChrysCapital as an investor. Along with this, we got recognized several times for our employee friendly work culture. It has been a great achievement that we have been certified as Great

Place To Work, twice in a row. In the year 2021, we underwent an extensive branding exercise and rebranded ourselves

HOW DOES ARAGEN LIFE SCIENCES COLLABORATE WITH AND DEVELOP RELATIONSHIPS WITH KEY SUPPLIERS AND WHAT BENEFITS AS A COMPANY DO YOU SEE FROM THIS COLLABORATION?

Highly engaged supplier base is very crucial for high performance of our supply chain on critical parameters of cost, OTIF and Compliance. It also helps us to improve our Agility, Competitive advantage and have better visibility of opportunities and challenges based on intelligence from our supplier systems. We have various interventions as below to engage our key suppliers or supply partners as we call them

i. Supplier Segmentation: We categorize our supply partners basis spend categories and various Risk associated with them, this helps us to prioritize the relationship with supply partners involved in high-risk procurement, those with the highest spend or strategic spend categories

ii. SRM Meetings: Strategy based discussion with senior management from both sides including value drivers like new offerings, risk reduction, Best Practices adoption, Green Initiatives, Technology Adaption etc are part of SRM meeting agenda. This helps in driving long term Strategic Alignment and Track and manage joint strategic initiatives

iii. Supply Partners Performance Management - Monthly Supply Partners performance is evaluated through Balance scorecard on critical parameters such as Value of spend, Delivery adherence, Credit terms, Quality performance, Documentation and final score is assigned. Basis the performance trend, focus areas of improvement are identified and respective Partners are engaged to improve the same

iv. Supply Partners Grievance Redressal – Process was designed to centralize and document, monitor and review the resolution of various grievances raised by

Various Partners. This is reviewed by SCM Head on weekly basis and updated to Management on monthly basis. Monthly grievances have got reduce by 30% and resolution time has improved by 40% in last 1 year resulting a more satisfied and engaged Partner's base.

v. Supply Partners Satisfaction Survey – Supply Partners satisfaction & feedback is utmost important in progress of any supply Chain team. Annual survey of top 80 % spend based Supply Partners was conducted on important parameters of Ethics, Compliance and Sustainability, Business Practices, Quality & accounting practices, Supply Partners Evaluations and Relationship process and Partnership. Overall score was improved by 15% over last year, with score of 4.3 on scale of 5

vi. Supplier base Consolidation: There is Constant focus to consolidate our supplier base across all spend categories focusing on tail

end spend, non-performing Supply Partners, High performing Supply Partners and Future business opportunities resulting in Improved Supply Partners relationship, increased purchasing power, Increase in compliance, reduced process cost & Reduced Risk.

vii. Forward Supply Opportunity engagement – Basis the feedback from Customers and in line with our business strategy, we continuously engage our Suppliers for potential projects across the spend categories to drive value from collaborated efforts and Innovation

ANYTHING ELSE YOU WOULD LIKE TO ADD OR EXPAND UPON?

As we step into this new phase where we have a brand new identity and a new investor joining us, we are excited to see what the future holds for us and look forward to the coming decade with our purpose of serving our customers and keeping them ahead in the race for better health.



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2021



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- * CII Award : Emerging Leader-excellence In Customer Management - 2017
- * CII Award : Business Excellence-maturity Assessment - 2018
- * CII Award : For Digitalization, Low Cost Automation & Robotics - 2019



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- * Value Engineering
- * Safety, Audit, and Training

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- * Build & Commission

MANAGED SERVICES

- * Lab Infra Management
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PRODUCTS

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- * Sinks
- * Emergency Equipment
- * Fixtures & Fittings
- * Accessories

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- * CFD design for HVAC
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LAB CONSTRUCTION

- * Kewaunee Green Guardian IOT Solution
- * K-Smart Project Management

LAB OPERATIONS

- * Digital Twins
- * KGG IOT
- * AR & VR Training

ACCREDITATIONS



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Padmabhushan Dr. Nageshwar Reddy
- Founder & Chairman

AIG HOSPITALS

PATIENTS FIRST - AIG HOSPITALS

FOUNDED IN 1986 WITH
LOTS OF FINANCIAL
STRUGGLES TO START AIG IS
NOW ONE OF THE LEADER IN
HEALTHCARE SECTOR

Padmabhushan Dr. Nageshwar Reddy Founder & Chairman shared his insights and AIG's Incredible journey.

Based on the strong pillars of dedicated and qualified staff, benchmarked protocols and practice, state-of-the-art tech and infrastructure, Asian Institute of Gastroenterology Hospital is one of the first healthcare gastroenterology Institute to enter India . Focused on redefining quality health care in India, "Our vision is to make people better and our desire is to instill the values of quality and excellence in every aspect of our work," Reddy states. "Attempting to deliver on these promises is truly the recipe for success. We push hard on early turnaround times and quicker decisions to ensure there is efficiency at all levels – clinical and non-clinical."

I have the opportunity to innovate, improve and generate positive strategic outcomes for our hospital and the patients they serve," he reveals. "It's by far one of my most exciting roles to date

Reddy's experience in the trenches of health care gives him a unique perspective when it comes to making the kind of business

decisions his role demands. "I'm able to bring clinical insight and knowledge to inform business operations, decisions and management for our private hospital as a business entity," he says.

As a Chairman in the health industry, I find one of the most important attributes you need is to be willing to constantly evolve and change your approach, according to the audience before you."

AIG strongly believes patients first and patient centric

"If we run a good business that looks after the people, then the profit element will follow

For Nageshwar Reddy, one of the most transformative aspects of AIG has been the freedom to set a distinctive internal culture. "This has been far more intense and hands-on than I'd intended in that first part," he tells.

"But it's actually been an opportunity to build a business and a culture from scratch. One of the things I'm most proud of in what we've achieved at AIG is developing a culture that is different. I think it's the key in our Institute."

The effort to develop this culture stems from Reddy's belief that if you really want to make a difference, you need to drive change from the executive management level. With the freedom to do exactly that, Reddy

has helped create an environment that recognizes the work of hospital administrators and allows hospital leaders to "blossom".

It's all about creating a rich culture of collaboration and support. for example "We don't talk about general political and cars or sports ," Reddy explains. "We talk about healthcare articles , innovations , because our whole reason for being is to support each other and sharing knowledge that allows them to deliver the best outcomes for their hospital and for their patients. We build support platforms and infrastructure that take some of the hard work out of the leadership role for those hospitals, and allow them to really get on with adding value around leading their team, looking after patients and meeting the needs of doctors."

It's a people-driven approach to management that's been evident in the way AIG has handled the COVID-19 crisis.

The advent of the COVID-19 pandemic has pushed the global healthcare industry to new limits; it's no different at AIG, but Reddy concedes the crisis isn't without its opportunities. "It's had an enormous impact, but through pandemic planning, we're well placed to adapt, evolve and shift our services to work within the virus's constraints," he says.

In AIG's case, this means digitizing a range of services, focusing on

community and patient engagement via online forums, and developing COVID-safe environments. "The safety of patients, staff and the community remains our focus, and we'll continue to adapt planning to ensure our hospital remain responsive and agile to the changing conditions," he insists.

We're thinking if we run a good business that looks after the people, then the profit element will follow," Andrew asserts. "We're not blind to profit because without that it's not a sustainable business. But we do make sure we're putting the focus on our people first.

AIG has also worked to maintain communication with its team, in part through the use of a counseling helpline for staff and doctors, and their immediate families. the priority, Reddy says,

revolves around acting in the best interests of staff, doctors and patients.

AIG Maintains high quality environment and as a Hospital we are very keen on Hygiene and a feel good atmosphere in the hospital .

We have a very strong relationship with all our suppliers and partners it's professional and cordial most importantly it's a win - win situation for all of us.

Talking about team at AIG– we continue to go from strength to strength "We are nurturing, supporting and growing the next generation of leaders in health care at our hospital," he enthuses. "And the area where we've seen the biggest difference over the past 20 years is in the capacity and strength of our incredible, talented, skilled and innovative leaders across all of

our teams." Our team is not just doctors but also researchers and scientists most importantly They are all quality clinicians

Today, Reddy's teams are achieving the mutual goal of excellence in patient care. "In many years to come, they'll be among some of the most impressive and innovative leaders across the entire health sector," he says.

The Chairman believes that India has a unique opportunity to provide care beyond its own people. "AIG believes that its offering – in ethical and evidence-based medical practices, operational excellence and value for money – would be attractive to a person who requires health care anywhere on the globe. We have qualified doctors to be part of the clinical excellence of what we do here."





5G NETWORKS

The fifth generation of the mobile internet is going to bring the kind of speed most people associate with Wi-Fi to uploading and downloading data from remote locations. This will lead to sharp improvements in the way applications can be written, deployed and interacted with by mobile users. This also includes the development of data-intensive applications and the Internet of Things (IOT) — physical objects with sensors that connect to and share data with the internet, autonomous vehicles and similar projects. Faster data transmission combined with increased bandwidth will be a powerful catalyst for innovation.

As businesses become more digital, the growth rate of the data and content being created is significant. According to Gartner, nearly 70% of businesses will engage in personal data archiving, a rapid jump from

10% in 2018. As a result, data-driven technologies will be a big growth area. This increases the importance of ensuring new technologies are being developed that protect data as businesses grow their digital footprint.

At the same time, security companies are building analytics to identify attacks in progress or breaches that have already happened. They are also looking for data and assets on the dark web so that the owners of that data can react as quickly as possible. How is your cybersecurity focus continuing to evolve and rise to the challenge, especially when considering IoT and AI advancements?

DATA ANALYTICS

is the collection, transformation, and organization of data in order to draw conclusions, make predictions, and drive informed decision making.

Over 8 courses, gain in-demand skills that prepare you for an entry-level job. You'll learn from Google employees whose foundations in data analytics served as launchpads for their own careers. At under 10 hours per week, you can complete the certificate in less than 6 months.

You'll prepare yourself for jobs that include junior or associate data analyst, database administrator, and more.

SEARCHING FOR A SMARTWATCH OR FITNESS TRACKER?

All the large smartwatch dispatches during the current year are essentially done. We have not one, but rather two new Apple Watches, another Samsung leader, and a few new Fitbits. There's likewise a solid appearance of spending alternatives, so you don't need to spend a ton on the off chance that you simply need something

straightforward. If you need to spare a piece by going for a last-gen smartwatch, right now is an ideal opportunity to likewise be watching out for limits as retailers attempt to dispose of their stock. Something else, save an eye for Black Friday arrangements and occasion deals.

THE BEST ALL-AROUND SMARTWATCH

It's a piece antique now to state that the Apple Watch is the best, particularly because the Series 6 is an iterative update. You're getting blood oxygen-checking using another SpO2 sensor, a consistently on the altimeter, better battery life (however it's as yet not multi-day), a more splendid consistently in plain view, and a new S6 processor. To the extent watch OS 7 goes, we preferred new highlights that appear to be intended for the pandemic, such as cycling bearings and handwashing clocks, however, a few things like the much-anticipated local rest following are simply alright. Also, presently, with Family Setup you could, if you needed, set up an Apple Watch for youngsters or old guardians who might not have iPhones. Nonetheless, while the Series 6 did squeeze out one more win as the best in the general watch, the opposition is one serious part nearer than in earlier years.

If you've been technology shopping recently, you will no doubt have caught sight of smart speakers everywhere. Here's a glance at all the things a smart speaker can do

that your dusty old sound system can't.

ENTERTAINMENT

No additionally looking through applications or record racks to discover the collection or tune you need to play straight away. You can stream music and videos over WIFI or Bluetooth, work with Chromecast devices, control your television, play games, and stream music to multiple speakers (multi-room audio).

QUICK NEWS & DATA

Recollect when you needed to go to a library to find a solution to a question? Be it Wikipedia data, news headlines, weather forecasts, current traffic conditions, or even date and time everything can be retrieved with just a command.

MANAGE YOUR DAY

Always forgetting meetings, losing the shopping list, or failing to remember significant birthday celebrations? Let a smart speaker recollect them for you, and offer up updates for every one of your occasions, as well. Disclose to it the thing or activity you need to be recollected or the date that needs noting, and it'll deal with everything for you. Smart speakers can set up appointments, give reminders, fill in as a morning alarm, and even maintain to-do lists.

HELP IN THE KITCHEN

Smart speakers are the ultimate kitchen assistants who can recite a whole recipe, set multiple timers,

get estimate measurement conversions, or even get nutrition values which can set you on ease.

CONTROL YOUR SMART HOME

An extraordinary aspect regarding smart speakers is that there's quite a lot more to them than just music. Boss among these capacities is the way that they can be utilized to control smart home gadgets, for example, turning the lights on or off (and dim them) with just your voice by just waking up your smart speaker.

The smart speakers are yet getting new abilities continuously however, they still do what's needed for you to dive in. From noting inquiries to playing your main tunes to requesting a taxi while in the shower, these speakers have shown high esteem – enough value to try them out in case you're one of those buyers who like to be a first mover.



THE FUTURE OF TECHNOLOGY AND DIGITAL

We are building the world's first cognitive cities. Through the use of real-time data and intelligence, will fundamentally change the way people interact and work, creating an interconnected harmony that offers an unparalleled quality of life. Today's consumers expect amazing feats of speed and service delivered through easy-to-use apps and personalized interactions. Modern conveniences, like online purchasing and curbside pickup, instant digital payments, and real-time ride sharing have taught consumers that the digital experience is paramount—no matter how big the company, how complex the problem, or how regulated the industry. Many of these consumer expectations have



been accelerated by the pandemic, but the pandemic was not their cause; it was just the most recent catalyst.

Across industries, digital innovators have continued to disrupt existing business models using software and data to deliver seamless, personalized experiences. For example, omni-channel experiences in retail have become the new normal for many consumers. Financial services empower consumers to interact with their bank in real time through mobile or online apps. And everyday, millions of people book and pay for a rideshare through their smartphones, expecting service in less than a few minutes. Innovation at this scale and speed has triggered massive business transformation—even cultural shifts—further reinforcing the notion to consumers that anything is possible.

It is an exciting time, but it's also a lot of pressure for businesses and development teams as consumers' expectations continue to grow. Consumption of digital experiences have only increased, and businesses are moving rapidly to survive and



thrive in this digital-first world.

TRANSFORMATION HINGES ON NEW CLOUD DATABASE CAPABILITIES

The first step to building all-new customer experiences is to select the operational database that will power your application and, in essence, run your business. Your choice of an operational database can either abstract away the complexity of delivering real-time application capabilities, empowering your development team to innovate, or it can

bottleneck and degrade the application development process, eating up valuable time on tasks like maintenance and scaling.

When building your operational database strategy, keep in mind the



following tenets of modern application development:

DOWNTIME CAN MAKE OR BREAK A BUSINESS.

New always-on business models require applications to be highly reliable and continuously available 24/7. With the accelerated consumption of digital experiences due to the pandemic, brands can no longer afford their applications to go down or risk losing customer trust.

Six considerations for a database strategy in a changing world

Digital innovators understand the power of having resilient, mission-critical systems that can seamlessly scale and reliably run your business 24/7, while managing the total cost of ownership of these initiatives. The right database gives you the critical capabilities that make a difference in our increasingly digital world. Let's take a look at some of the key components of a modern database strategy.

Serve every user anywhere

Processes that once took IT teams weeks or months with on-premises systems, like scaling database resources across geographies, can now be handled in just a few clicks. With the growth of always-on

customer culture, enterprises face competitive pressure to deliver positive experiences to every user across the globe.

DELIVER HIGH AVAILABILITY AND RESILIENCY.

For mission-critical systems, there's little room for error, and a highly available cloud database can ensure a certain amount of operability even when a data center or instance becomes unavailable. To meet the heightened expectations of digital users, organizations need to be able to quickly recover from an outage or emergency and maintain persistent operations.

INCORPORATE AUTOMATION.

When a cloud database is highly automated, IT teams save time and money on tasks like scaling, backups, and patching, which also reduces human error and shrinks security risk by limiting unnecessary access by team members. Developers can iterate and deploy quickly through automated provisioning and management that simplifies the process for creating, modifying, cloning, and duplicating database servers.

PRIORITIZE PORTABILITY AND OPEN STANDARDS.

Cloud databases can enable an organization to access, copy, move, and reuse data across multiple applications, platforms, and environments. This breaks down data silos, unlocks more power of your data, prevents vendor lock-in, and makes the best use of your various products and systems. This allows enterprises to meet the growing demands of data sovereignty for easier and stricter compliance.

SECURITY SHOULD BE PARAMOUNT.

With the new level of sophistication of bad actors, and new stringent data protection and privacy standards, security and privacy have become fundamental to the survival of a business. Your database strategy should go beyond baseline security methods and include robust measures such as secure-by-

design infrastructure, built-in data protection and replication, and multi-layered security. Your data security and governance procedures need to work hand-in-hand to protect your organization and allow you to innovate safely.

COST EFFICACY.

Fully managed cloud databases do more than save enterprises money on database administrators and maintenance—with highly customizable settings, they deliver cost savings for their target use cases and workloads. Whether it's a high-throughput consumer application or an enterprise business intelligence application, cloud databases deliver optimal performance at lower cost.

With the right components, an operational cloud database can power your applications to meet the growing demands of our increasingly digital culture, reliably serve customers across the globe, and help you respond more quickly and easily to unexpected conditions.

The Internet of Things (IoT) is a rapidly-growing modern technology that uses a network of physical objects or things driven by the internet to collect and exchange data. The data or information is gathered and interchanged with the help of in-built sensors. Since the communication between the devices is wireless, IoT has become immensely popular, and its application ranges over a broad spectrum of industries. As per McKinsey reports, 127 IoT devices around the world are connected to the internet every second.

The advanced techniques and innovation in IoT have attracted both consumers and media alike. Smart devices in IoT seamlessly connect to other devices or the cloud through the internet and produce productive and valuable data. That's why IoT has succeeded in creating a massive economic wave worldwide.

According to reports by the McKinsey Global Institute, the annual economic impact of IoT is

expected to hit a whopping \$3.9 trillion to \$11.1 trillion by 2025.

IoT acts as a strong liaison between the physical and digital worlds where communication happens with minimal human intervention. So rippling has been the impact of the IoT technology that its applications are a part of our day-to-day lives (think thermostats, cars, and kitchen appliances).

This article will explore the technologies that have shaped the Internet of Things and take an in-depth look at real-life IoT applications.

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- Network Connectivity
- Cloud Computing Platforms
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- Smart Home
- Wearable IoT
- Smart Cities
- Connected Cars
- Industrial Internet
- Agricultural IoT
- Smart Retail
- Smart Energy Management
- Connected Healthcare
- IoT in Farming and Poultry
- Smart Lighting
- IoT in Traffic Management and Road Toll Collection
- Smart Parking
- Waste Management
- Water Conservation

Smart Home

The most popular real-time application of IoT is the smart home, as it is affordable and readily available. The voices of the customers can control many IoT products in the market. Examples of such products are Amazon Echo,

temperature sensors (both digital and analogue), ultrasonic sensors for measuring the water level, lux sensors to measure luminosity, video cameras for safety and surveillance, and a Nest thermostat. Face recognition technology alleviates the need for physical keys to open and lock the house. The users can enable face recognition for the family members, so strangers can't break into the house.

WEARABLE IOT

Watches are no longer limited to telling time. Smartwatches like Apple Watch have digitalized consumer's wrists by facilitating text messages, phone calls, and so on. Other smart IoT wearables like Jawbone and Fitbit have revamped the world of fitness by providing all minute details about working out like calories burnt, the distance walked, heart rate and even weight.

SMART CITIES

Smart and digitized cities can be created using IoT. IoT can recast an entire city by addressing the real-life issues faced by the citizens like traffic jams, roadblocks, excessive noise, violations, and pollution with the help of data and proper connectivity. In short, IoT can rebuild an entire city with ease.

CONNECTED CARS

Vehicles can be connected to the internet and remotely controlled by the owner. The sensors perform all the functions for the owners like starting the vehicle, setting alarms, locking & unlocking with an intelligent lock system, and opening the boot. Vehicles can be completely digitalized and made autonomous with modern IoT technology.

INDUSTRIAL INTERNET

The Industrial Internet is a revolution of the industrial sector. Also known as the Industrial Internet of Things (IIoT), the concept aims at providing efficient software, robust sensors, and analytics to produce smart machines. IoT assures quality control and sustainability. The main applications

of IoT are tracking goods, real-time notifications from the inventory to the suppliers, and automated delivery. This dramatically improves the demand-supply efficiency.

AGRICULTURAL IOT

Agriculture has become the primary focal point in many countries as the world is challenged by the growing population and demand for food supply. The Agricultural Internet of Things aims at assisting farmers in increasing food production. Smart farming has become the norm in many parts of the world. Farmers are given valuable insights from the accumulated data. They are given information on soil nutrient requirements, soil moisture, controlled use of water, optimal use of fertilizers according to their soil, etc.

SMART RETAIL

The potential of IoT in retail is tremendous. It helps the retailers to connect better with their customers and enhance customer service. The retailers can connect with their customers out of the store as well through smartphones and Beacon technology. The retail IoT helps retailers to identify the areas of high traffic and place their premium products accordingly.

SMART ENERGY MANAGEMENT

IoT has made the power grids smart and highly reliable. The Smart grid concept is to automate data collection and use the data to observe the behavior pattern of suppliers and consumers. This helps to improve energy efficiency and optimize its use. Smart grids can sense power disruptions much faster and help with uniform power distribution.

CONNECTED HEALTHCARE

IoT in healthcare is the most demanded feature in today's world. Connected healthcare and automated medical devices are a boon to healthcare companies and the common public. Reports suggest a massive surge in the application of IoT in healthcare. The main objective of IoT in healthcare is to empower people to lead a



healthy and vigilant life with the help of smart devices connected to them to track every parameter. The devices collect relevant information that can provide an individual's complete health report and the necessary strategies to tackle illness (if any).

IOT IN FARMING AND POULTRY

Livestock tracking is the backbone of animal rearing. With the help of IoT applications, ranchers can track the health of cattle and prevent animals from contracting mass infections. The collected data can be used to increase poultry production through cost-effective techniques.

SMART LIGHTING

This is a modern application of IoT that is slowly becoming popular. Bulbs and battens connected to the internet can be operated from any place through voice recognition technology. Other factors like brightness and power consumption can also be monitored.

IoT in Traffic Management and Road Toll Collection

Using the data generated by IoT devices and cameras, traffic authorities can operate the traffic lights on busy highways and roads. This makes road journeys much safer and regulated. Toll collection has been made wholly automated with IoT. This detects the approaching vehicles and automatically imposes the barrier. The barrier is lifted only after collecting the toll fee.

SMART PARKING

Imposing parking regulations in multi-storied buildings is a challenging task. With the advent of IoT, this has been made easier and more convenient. The IoT devices will keep a tab of the number of cars parked and exited cars. This helps the drivers to know the available parking slots. Specialized IoT devices can help car owners by letting them know the exact location of their car parking.

WASTE MANAGEMENT

Waste management is a serious challenge posed to many city authorities. Many cities do not have an efficient waste management system because of the lack of standard management tools and defined routes for the garbage trucks to carry the waste. IoT devices can help the authorities to track the movement of the garbage trucks, observe the loading capacity of the dump yards, and improve the overall efficiency of the process.

WATER CONSERVATION

Common people and industrial facilities are often unaware of the local water bodies (underground storage and overhead tanks) and their levels. IoT systems can keep track of the water level. This allows people to know about water consumption and optimize the same. The bigger picture also helps the city authorities monitor water body levels and impose strategies to improve water conservation. It also raises an alert when the water levels are alarmingly high.



TRAVEL



TO
TRAVEL
IS TO
LIVE
HANS CHRISTIAN
ANDERSEN

The 2020-2021 pandemic has acted as a near or complete brake and break, on many activities, behaviors, and ideas that prevailed before shots and masks and social distancing took precedence in the lives of many. It has been a time of prohibition, yet also, a time of rejuvenation, due in part of the ideas of wellness, rejuvenation, and regeneration that have taken the spotlight.

Concepts of wellness have been with us for many years, but in the past months, they have moved to more global, needful perspectives, touching industries, businesses and manufacturing like never before. Just as the pandemic has transformed our world view, so has it also allowed wellness in all its dimensionality to move forward –as a permanent solution, not a mere palliative, to many issues that have needed clarification and resolution for years.

The newly-opened Patina Maldives Hotel located within the Fari Islands should be on the bucket list of any

thalassophile. Not only does it look breathtaking from the outside, but it is even more luxurious on the inside.

You don't have to go to the extreme when on a quest for both elegance and functionality. This summer escapade destination boasts both contemporary and modern design with its use of natural tones, both in the pieces of furniture and in the furnishings. There is a sense of cohesion, of being one with the topography.

This is in keeping with the hotel's goal to use only sustainably sourced or eco-friendly materials. As such, the hotel uses locally sourced, biodegradable, and reusable materials for its frame and interior design.

Speaking of topography, a vast of greenery from lush trees surround the Patina Maldives Hotel on the ground. Meanwhile, beautiful sparkling blue-green waters encompass one side, overlooking and connecting the terrace for great views of the sea.

The hotel is comprised of 90 villas designed by Brazilian architect Marcio Kogan characterized by their surroundings.

There are land villas and over-water villas. The accommodations range from one to three bedrooms but both have outdoor showers and interiors that blend seamlessly with the natural landscape.

Then there are also outdoor bathtubs, private gardens, big private pools, floor-to-ceiling windows, and butler service so you can simply relax and unwind.

The hotel is comprised of 90 villas designed by Brazilian architect Marcio Kogan characterized by their surroundings.

To keep you connected, the Patina Maldives Hotel also offers Wi-Fi. Likewise,

entertainment is provided via a smart TV and gaming consoles including the Xbox and Nintendo.

Theow far can you run in your travels, before being pulled back into the turning wheel?



LIFE STYLE

Spring is here, and not a moment too soon! As we move into the warmer months of 2021, hot new lifestyle trends are beginning to emerge. Unsurprisingly, many of these trends are a response to the challenges we all faced in 2020. They truly speak to the resolve and innovation we were able to achieve amid the adversity of this past year.

These new trends also indicate our collective desire for a brighter future and better health and wellbeing. We are seeing more and more people dedicated to making their health a priority. It's clear that better mental, physical, planetary, educational, and professional health will influence not only this year but also the years to come.

So, let's explore six healthy lifestyle trends we're going to see in 2021!

1. CONSUMER INTEREST IN SUSTAINABILITY AND TRANSPARENCY

Few things are as encouraging as a societal shift toward creating a cleaner and safer planet for the

future. And that's exactly what's happening!

A considerable part of this shift involves dietary changes. How we produce and consume food and water has a massive impact on the health of our planet.

Choosing plant-based foods and alternative protein sources can help

ease the impact food production has on the Earth. This dietary shift results in a lower reliance on meat and utilizes highly available natural resources like land and water. So, just by loving plant-based foods, you're helping create a greener and healthier planet!



Isagenix has a TON of plant-based products that are delicious, full of nutrients, and eco-conscious! Check out our and for superfood meal replacement options or our Harvest Thins™ for healthy, plant-powered snacks!

OUR SUSTAINABILITY EFFORTS

We're also seeing a trend of large companies making significant eco-friendly commitments. At Isagenix, we're proud of the commitments that we've made toward a greener tomorrow. We're committed to choosing environmentally friendly packaging for our products and integrating sustainable materials and ethical ingredient sourcing into the products we are so happy to provide.



2. HOLISTIC HEALTH AND WELLNESS

Taking a holistic approach to health isn't necessarily a new trend, but it is evolving with new ideas, products, and practices. For example, more people are using food for better physical and mental health. Holistic nutrition is all about eating healthy food in its natural state — whole foods — for optimal health and wellbeing.

We're also seeing a general movement toward nurturing ourselves. People are becoming more and more aware of their health and what they can do at home to support their overall wellness. That means deeper self-care, more focus on wellness, at-home fitness, and investing in

health and wellness products.

Many people are also taking a more holistic approach to exercise as a piece of a larger wellness goal rather than simply a way to lose weight or gain strength. This technique aims to balance exercise with restorative activities like sleep and meditation.

5. TIME IN THE GREAT OUTDOORS

Warmer weather and cabin fever are reminding people how great it is to get outside and enjoy nature!

One specific part of this trend is an increase in visits to U.S. national parks and forests. According to National Park Service data, Yellowstone National Park saw a 21% increase in visits in September

2020 compared to 2019. Park visitor numbers across the country are expected to continue to rise this year as Americans flock to wide-open spaces to explore the treasures of the country.

Interest in nature fits right in with the trend of people wanting to live healthier lives — healthy lands inspire healthy minds and healthy bodies. And it's a trend that's likely to accelerate as we move into our semi-quarantined lifestyles.

CULTURAL TRENDS

Unlike past years, changes in human psyche, social behavior and technological adoption are remarkably visible. Around the world, people have been forced to adjust their lifestyles in radical

ways. Because of the pandemic, we are experiencing years of behavior change packed into a few short months. Here are six cultural trends focused on emerging consumer behavior that will predictably shape the next decade.

NEW VIRTUAL WORLDS

The promise of an expansive virtual world, competing with our physical reality has been prophesied for decades. As depicted in blockbuster movies like Blade Runner, The Matrix and Ready Player One. The global pandemic—largely physical distancing—has wedged a divide between people in society. Many are now migrating to digital environments to fulfill the human need to connect with others. In 2021, the conditions are finally ripe for a virtual existence.

Currently, gaming is at the forefront of the rapid shift from physical to virtual experiences. Platforms like Fortnite, Minecraft and Roblox have built complex worlds described as The Metaverse: a shared virtual space where people can create new identities, explore endless possibilities and spend time with friends. Within the next decade, virtual spaces will become an integral part of our collective human experience. We will spend as much, if not more time in the virtual realm. Everyday use cases will include going to work as 3D avatars. Virtual relationships and families minus physical interaction. And regular livestreamed concerts, games and movie premieres—with no physical origins—enjoyed concurrently by millions of people around the world.

EDITORS' PICK | Feb 26

2021,08:33pm EST | 20,604 views

CULTURAL TRENDS THAT WILL SHAPE CONSUMER BEHAVIOR IN 2021 AND BEYOND

Cultural trends for 2021 and beyond.

Unlike past years, changes in human psyche, social behavior and technological adoption are remarkably visible. Around the world, people have been forced to



adjust their lifestyles in radical ways. Because of the pandemic, we are experiencing years of behavior change packed into a few short months. Here are six cultural trends focused on emerging consumer behavior that will predictably shape the next decade.

The virtual world will undoubtedly reshape society. Its impact will be equal to the invention of the internet and cuneiform. For companies, this new uncharted universe represents a commercial opportunity to 10x revenue. Comparisons can be made with the rise of Western Europe after the 1500s with access to the Atlantic Ocean, trade and colonialism in the New World. In many ways, control of the virtual world will be more lucrative than colonizing space. At the moment, the best entry point for brands is at the intersection between e-gaming and social media.

A food item that provides all types of beneficial nutrients such as protein, vitamins, minerals, amino acids, fatty acids and fiber. Such food also minimizes intake of harmful elements such as sodium, saturated fats, and sugars, the paper noted.

"Nutrient profiling" or the rating of foods based on their nutrient density (i.e., nutrient content per 100 g or per 100 kcal of energy or

per serving) has evolved substantially in recent years as an approach to classifying individual foods as more or less nutritious, the paper mentioned.

Authors Lynnette M Neufeld, Sheryl Hendriks, and Marta Hugus highlighted that there were "still a number of gaps in improving the ability to characterise foods as more or less nutritious".

While nutrient requirements differed according to sex, age and life stage, no single nutrient requirement value can be defined even within age or sex groups.

| Monsoon diet: Your perfect guide to healthy eating is here

The authors also pointed out the lack of database when it comes to less common food items such as 'edible insects'.

DOES A HEALTHY LIFESTYLE MAKE A DIFFERENCE?

As it turns out, healthy habits make a big difference. According to this analysis, people who met criteria for all five habits enjoyed significantly, impressively longer lives than those who had none: 14 years for women and 12 years for men (if they had these habits at age 50). People who had none of these habits were far more likely to die prematurely from cancer or cardiovascular disease.

Study investigators also calculated life expectancy by how many of these five healthy habits people had. Just one healthy habit (and it didn't matter which one) ... just one... extended life expectancy by two years in men and women. Not surprisingly, the more healthy habits people had, the longer their lifespan. This is one of those situations where I wish I could reprint their graphs for you, because they're so cool. (But if you're very curious, the article is available online, and the graphs are on page 7. Check out Graph B, "Estimated life expectancy at age 50 according to the number of low-risk factors.")

This is huge. And, it confirms prior similar research — a lot of prior similar research. A 2017 study using data from the Health and Retirement Study found that people 50 and older who were normal weight, had never smoked, and drank alcohol in moderation lived on average seven years longer. A 2012 mega-analysis of 15 international studies that included over 500,000 participants found that over half of premature deaths were due to unhealthy lifestyle factors such as poor diet, inactivity, obesity, excessive alcohol intake, and smoking. And the list of supporting research goes on.



THE NEW LAMBORGHINI HURACÁN STO BRINGS THE TRACK TO THE STREETS

While inspiration images for the new Lamborghini Huracán STO were released in November 2020, after multiple years of design and production, the street-homologated super sports car is now available for purchase. Drawing inspiration from Lamborghini Huracán Super Trofeo EVO and GT3 EVO race cars, this unique Lamborghini brings superior aerodynamics and race car engineering to street driving. It also has a V10 naturally aspirated 640 hp engine which propels the car from 0-62 mph in 3.0 seconds, 0-124 mph in 9.0 seconds and a top speed of 193 mph.

Its entirely new exterior design is a unique lightweight solution which revises the inimitable

Lamborghini profile to optimize airflow. A result from the collaboration between Lamborghini's R&D, Squadra Corse and Centro Stile departments, highlights of some of the

aerodynamic solutions include: carbon fiber in more than 75% of its exterior panels (which reduces the weight of the vehicle by 95 lbs. compared to the already lightweight



Huracán Performante), 20% lighter windscreen, magnesium rims, a new rear fender with NACA air intake, the cofango - combines the 'cofano' (hood) and 'parafango' (fender) including the front bumper - with air ducts, front splitter and louvers and much more.

Its interior and exterior have both been designed with a purpose, giving the pilot a race car experience on the road. From the moment the engine is fired up with much gusto, the pilot is immersed in the Lamborghini driving experiences. Its engine has been calibrated for a very sporty and responsive racing feel, where the true roar and power of the vehicle isn't seen until the car hits 5,000 rpm. Its rear-wheel steering creates a more intimate relationship between car and driver with a highly responsive and rapid gearshift and three ANIMA driving modes, STO (road driving and fun on curving roads), Trofeo (optimized for dry asphalt and the fastest lap times on track) and Pioggia (rain, which optimizes traction control, torque vectoring, rear-wheel steering and the ABS on wet



racing driver, daily, in a road-legal Lamborghini super sports car able to take lap records," said Reggiani. Reflecting the engineering of its lightweight exterior, the interior of the car also has extensive use of carbon throughout (cockpit, seats, floor mats, door panels) and an Alcantara interior with Lamborghini's Carbonskin. The new Human Machine Interface (HMI) graphics feature on the Huracán's 8.4-inch touch screen, manages the car's functions including drive mode indicator, the LDVI system, tire pressures and brake temperatures.

exterior and interior of the vehicle with limitless paint and trim combinations as well as race-style vinyls.

Currently the vehicle has been launched with a livery of Blu Laufey and Arancio California, which exemplifies the Huracán STO's young and sporty racing spirit. The first customers will take delivery of the new Lamborghini Huracán STO in Spring 2021.

World's First Tesla-Powered Range Rover Classic Introduced

E.C.D. Automotive Design (E.C.D.), the world's leader for custom and restored Land Rovers and Defenders introduced the first Electric Range Rover Classic (R.R.C.) powered by a Tesla motor direct drivetrain. The journey for this electric build began several months ago when E.C.D. partnered with Electric Classic Cars (E.C.C.), U.K.'s leader in electric conversions of classic vehicles, to secure the Tesla motor. After about 2,200-hour luxury design experience, countless customization options, E.C.D. completely stripped down, transforming and modernizing the client's Range Rover Classic while staying true to its original look and heritage.

E.C.D.'s build process takes place in their 45,000 square foot "Rover Dome" facility, where the truck travelled through 12 bays, each filled with 50 specialized technicians and master certified craftsmen. From electronic upgrades like cutting edge audio and in-dash navigation systems to



asphalt).

"The extensive technical solutions and intelligence gained from both our Super Trofeo and GT3 programs has been refined and embodied in the Huracán STO, allowing the pilot to experience the emotions of a

Owners of the Huracán STO can also make use of the fully connected telemetry system to monitor and record their performance and to analyze the data via the Lamborghini UNICA app. They are also able to fully customize both the



design icon Battista 'Pinin' Farina.

Limited to just five vehicles worldwide, it represents the pinnacle of Automobile Pininfarina's design philosophy, with aerodynamic enhancements and tailored detailing providing a uniquely dynamic personality.

As part of an extensive program prepared for Automobile Pininfarina's clients in North America, the exclusive hyper GT will be joined at the Pebble Beach Concours D'Elegance by a fleet of iconic Pininfarina designed vehicles to celebrate more than 90 years of design excellence.

The Anniversario features a unique Automobile Pininfarina designed livery and bi-color tinted Furiosa Pack consisting of front splitter, side blades and rear diffuser, with outer carbon parts finished in black exposed signature carbon and inner parts in exposed signature carbon tinted in Iconica Blu.

At the Pebble Beach Concours D'Elegance, three special judging classes will showcase Pininfarina's 91 years of history, with a cavalcade of iconic Pininfarina designs celebrating the unrivaled design heritage which has inspired the form of the Battista hyper GT. Automobile Pininfarina Chief Design Officer, Luca Borgogno, will join the panel of honorary judges at this year's Pebble Beach Concours d'Elegance.

The Battista will be presented in

cosmetic options like seat upholstery stitching and wet sanded exteriors for a polished finish to luxurious add-ons such as drink cabinets – no detail went undermined. The Tesla motor is packaged with a 100-kWh battery pack that can quickly drive up to an estimated 220 miles on a five-hour charge, reaching 0-60 mph in an impressive 5.2 seconds.

"Being leaders in the luxury custom car industry, it was important to us to expand our offerings into the electric market," said Tom Humble, founder of E.C.D. Automotive. "Now that we have finished the Electric Range Rover Classic we're going to continue to innovate and electrify Defenders and other Land Rovers. We offer our clients world class customization, and we are excited to add this new electric option to our truck build."

This Electric R.R.C. is finished in a glossy Alpine White paint, creating a striking contrast with the black grille and compliments the silver metal front and rear bumpers. Along with 18" Land Rover Boost 5 Spoke wheels and Continental Cross Contact Tires, the R.R.C. features classic interior elements such as tan leather seating, a dark wood finish on the dash and custom vertical diamond stitching throughout. The E.C.D. Electric lineup developed to comply with the California vehicle regulations and is currently 50 state

compliant.

Electric Dream: Introducing Automobile Pininfarina Battista Hyper GT At Monterey Car Week

The finished Battista features distinctive black exposed signature carbon fiber bodywork and black gloss precision polished Impulsorims. Inside, the first production-spec model features black sustainable luxury leather with striking Iconica Blu contrast stitching and quilted Pilot a seats in Iconica Blu Alcantara. The seats feature Pilota Carbon Components finished in black exposed signature carbon coordinating with the striking exterior.

Monterey Car Week will also see the US premiere of the exclusive Battista Anniversaries, itself a tribute to the life and work of



production specification for the first time globally after being crafted by Pininfarina's team of artisans in Italy. The 1,900hp electric hyper GT is the fastest and most powerful Italian sports car ever made, and each example will deliver the pinnacle of sustainable luxury.

As part of the forthcoming US program, clients will experience the interior and exterior soundscapes of the pure-electric model for the first time. Its specially developed soundtrack will elevate the driving experience while preserving the unique sensations of piloting a high-performance electric vehicle. The Automobile Pininfarina Battista is named after Battista 'Pinin' Farina, the founder of the Carrozzeria Pininfarina coachbuilding company, which he established in 1930.

The hyper GT is the realization of Battista's dream to see a car produced wearing the Pininfarina name, with the first vehicles due to be delivered to customers later this year. No more than 150 Battista hyper GTs will be created for clients worldwide. North America and Europe will account for the majority of sales, followed by the Middle East and Asia.

The exclusive hyper GT is priced from \$2.2m and is available to order through a global network of specialist retailers. Across North America, this presence includes retailers in San Francisco, Los Angeles, Denver, Dallas, Toronto, New York, Miami and Vancouver. The Battista is available with up to 10 years of manufacturer warranty



for ultimate peace of mind.

Battista Anniversario at Lake Como, Italy

2021 CADILLAC ESCALADE SPORT

Floating down I-95 towards Savannah at 75-miles-per-hour in the new Cadillac Escalade Sport, I

felt like a yachtsman at the helm. Though the Caddy on asphalt was smoother than any boat on water. Sitting behind its sweeping dashboard of frameless OLED screens and glossy wood, with a plush and perforated leather seat beneath me, I realized it was the first time I'd driven a vehicle that truly comes into its own when you put it in cruise control. Some cars are meant to wrestle corners at speed, some are meant to haul things, and some to climb mountains. But the Escalade, it seems, is meant to coddle whoever's inside it. And it delivers the same joy to the passengers as it does to the driver.

STYLING AND EXTERIOR

The newly-redesigned exterior is sleek and aggressive, though if you squint it looks like, well, an Escalade. They're not alienating anyone with any devious design choices, just cleaning things up a bit to keep it fresh. The model I drove was Crystal White, which made details like the new front grille stand out. I liked that there's a lot of open space in the 12-spoke gloss-black alloy wheels, giving the visual sense that this luxuriant beast is floating on its wheels.

When I arrived at the posh Perry Lane Hotel in Savannah, we were greeted by a patrician valet—a towering man whose first words when we opened the door were: "Everyone around here calls me Pops."

His second words, after looking over the Escalade, were, "Nice ride."

Valets have the occupational opportunity to develop strong opinions about cars, and Pops was as shrewd as they come. If the Escalade had his approval, then it most certainly had mine.

HANDLING AND PERFORMANCE

The 6.2L V8 is as powerful as it sounds, but given the Escalade Sport's roughly 5,800 pound curb weight, it still won't exactly be zipping around town. But nor will it ever struggle. The Escalade never stops feeling big, but nor does it ever feel sluggish. It is as powerful as it needs to be to carry its weight well, and you don't buy this to take it to the track unless you're going to bet on horses.

The official MPG numbers are 14 city/19 highway. I never got particularly close to 19, and was glad that I filled the massive tank during a mid-pandemic low point in gas prices. The 10-speed automatic transmission is so smooth you won't notice it shifting gears, and the 4WD would make this a viable choice for a winter mountain trip.

I had one issue with the safety features that I feel compelled to mention: a man was walking towards me on the shoulder of the freeway, and I was driving in the right lane. The Front Pedestrian Braking system registered the man as being in the road, and dramatically applied the brakes. It was a jarring experience, potentially dangerous, and I hope it's worked out in future updates.

INTERIOR

The interior is the reason you buy this Escalade. The thought I kept having was that if I were going to drive to Montana with five adults for a luxury fly-fishing or hunting trip, I would want to do it in an Escalade. The model I drove had an MSRP of 107k, but you do get to feel and touch the money spent here—it's not just under the hood. It's the OLED screens, the wide leather seats with their headrest speakers, the massive sunroofs, the rear-seat intercom, and the big and colorful Cadillac badge at the center of the leather-wrapped steering wheel. It's in the fact that you can turn your head in any direction and see expensive materials stretching out through a vast interior space.

Driving on open road in this Escalade, you just feel like you've got a real piece of luxury real estate around you, and if you're going to stop and get out, the reason had better be good.



Mr. Yatin Shah - Chairman & Managing Director

PRECISION CAMSHAFTS LIMITED

WHERE PASSION MEETS PERFORMANCE

WHAT WERE THE OPPORTUNITIES YOU SAW FOR YOURSELF AND THE COMPANY WHEN YOU DECIDED TO TAKE ON THE ROLE?

My father ran a business that was engaged in manufacturing tractor components consisting of a foundry and a machine shop which was a partnership concern. I had joined somewhere around 1988-1989 after my post-graduation from Simba Education. I did an MBA there and joined in as a partnership concern and was working for about 4 or 5 years. The business significantly introduced new changes that were talked to me during my college days in Symbiosis. Having said that I've always felt a little claustrophobic because it was a partnership concern and too many people had too many things to say from the business so I just decided to quit the business and start my own in roughly around 1993-1994 where I kept out of a large organization and a possible heir to the organization of the company. I said "No, I quit" and decided to start proceeding in camshafts set up in those days as a machine shop which was a smaller facility, like a garage of 1,200 sq. ft. shed and about 5,000 sq. ft. plot area. I started my business with a very small number of around 600 camshafts a month at that point in time which we paid for roughly 5 people including me. My first balance sheet at that point in time which I signed for was roughly



about 7 lakhs. From there onwards, it has been a consistent and very challenging roller coaster ride. We've gone through a lot of ups and downs. We stuck to my knitting as my core business and stuck to camshafts. Fast forward to now and Precision Camshafts is spread over to almost about 50 acres of land. Now it has 4 foundries and 4 machine shops. We have grown from a number of 7,200 camshafts per month to now close to 11 million. Now we also have 4 foundries that manufacture 11 million camshafts and machines about 4 million. It's a story that began with a scratch. I did not inherit anything. It started with me and it has grown significantly with the aid of some fantastic team members who were committed from Day 1 till now. So Precision Camshafts not only has those significantly doing camshafts but we've also acquired companies in Germany, a company in the

Netherlands, and a company in Nashik. We do different things besides camshafts. So obviously now we've become a multinational company. We're now engaged in manufacturing different products besides Camshafts. So we have insulated the rifts of becoming a single product company. All of this within a lifetime has been a very good achievement and I would say that I'm pretty content with what has happened. In spite of all of this, I still feel very excited when I got to the office every morning. That is one reforming challenge.

WHAT ARE THE PLANS FOR THE COMPANY'S GROWTH IN THE MEDIUM TO LONG TERM, SAY 3 TO 5 YEARS' TIME?

I think we are on rapid growth. We have acquired three companies. Precision Camshafts focuses on a growing path. All I can say is that we intend to exploit opportunities for all the companies that we've

undergone in the Precision group and grow them significantly over the coming years besides looking at new acquisition opportunities. So to put a number, right now we have around 800 crores of turnover. What you would want to become in 5 years, we have that as a number and we have what we want to do.

money in the bank and we are a highly profitable organization. Right now there are challenges that the auto components are facing which makes them uncertain for the next three months but we're seeing clear visibility for the next 3-5 years. So when you ask, what is it that you want to improve, we constantly say that we have a model that we run

or an electric vehicle. So that means that by the year 2025, we want to be a company that manufactures 50 percent Camshafts and 50 Percent Non-Auto Camshafts. I could have easily said I can do this 6 or 7 years from now but progressively thinking, honestly the desk technology is constantly engaging with the best in the world.



WHAT ARE ALL THE KEY AREAS OF FOCUS FOR YOUR COMPANY TO IMPROVE OVER NEXT 12-18 MONTHS?

This goes back to the way we work around the PCL/DNN culture. The PCL/DNN culture is pretty much unique in its own way. We believe in this culture of what you would call total transparency working with partners, discipline, regimented manufactures, and a conservative financial approach. All of this put together is the way we've been running our business. I'm not in a component business and we are a debt-free company. We're a highly profitable organization. That's not what you would hear from an auto component industry today in the market because not many people would tell you that we are a debt-free company. We have lots of

the business with. But we're always in the search of saying, what is it that we can do now to provide better services to the customer, how can we improve our own performance, how can we become more profitable. We question our own business model constantly, for instance, let's put it in this way, Precision Camshafts is doing Camshafts as the name suggests. Electric vehicles do not need Camshafts. That's a long story, maybe 10-15 years. I think we're recognizing that we don't need to start looking at that 10 years from now. We start looking at opportunities to mitigate with beginning today so we have planned that from the year 2025, we would be a company that does a lot of other products which are either tools, cars, which will always be there irrespective if it's a diesel car

Challenging our own beliefs has been key to the PCL working. Even we're content with what we're doing. We're always trying to challenge everything that we do, be it a manufacturing process or business practices. It is something that we always find and the good part about it is that we're a highly internally developed company. We do not seek consultants. Nothing that we have done so far has been in the aid of consultants. This has been homegrown and done by the team internally. This has been done by the people who worked and have managed to satisfy the best of the best customers in the world with talent from Solapur.

WHAT DO YOU BELIEVE SETS PRECISION CAMSHAFTS APART FROM ITS COMPETITORS?

The first step is away from our competition. I think we in our space of business, our Camshafts are recognized as the global benchmarks in terms of quality. So we are benchmarked along with the rest of the others. If Precision Camshafts can achieve this quality level, why can't you? So automatically that's the level that we've established and have been consistent for the last 20 years. It's not that we do this once a month. I think most customers that we operate with believe that we're the benchmark to be in business. Now, this comes out of great passion and commitment towards what we do. So we don't think it's worth it but it's something that we enjoy. If you come to our facilities, 45 acres, I think it's a place you would love to come and work. Because in a 45 acre, where in the world would you see 16 acres covered in lawns? We are committed to a green cover. It is much better than sending you to the city in the traffic where it's congested. I think people find this as a good place to work. In fact, I would often say that this is a lovely resort to come to work. So our quality level separates us from everybody and that comes out of the passion we have for our work, that we must believe we're the best and nothing else.

HOW HAVE YOU ACTUALLY WORKED WITH YOUR SUPPLIERS OVER THE YEARS TO FORM STABLE PARTNERSHIPS?

When you run a business and when it's successful or when it's consistently doing good, you owe the success to almost every stakeholder in the business. So one stakeholder is your shareholder who gives you the money to run the business and the other stakeholders are customers because of whom

we're here today. The third stakeholder is obviously the people who manufacture Camshafts and deliver them at good quality. Both stakeholders are the people who supply us with the material of which we can do it. So to hear me correctly, I have clearly prioritized the ranking for stakeholders. Without the shareholders I would not be in my place, a shareholder being me. If I had not put the money in business, Precision Camshafts would not have been here. My primary obligation and commitment go to the shareholder because the shareholder has put the money. We were able to put up the facilities and go to the customers who gave us the business, so that was also a stakeholder. The third stakeholder who's very important in this entire thing is the fantastic team that does this, I mean one has to look at saying how can you satisfy for sure with the people. You need skillsets, commitment, passion, you need all of that and that's an important stakeholder to me which is a priority. Obviously, unfortunately, you may not hear that the suppliers are an important stakeholder but on the ladder, they come last. Look when all this is set up, you're obviously going to have people coming and saying "Can I do this business with you? So when you want to do business then it's okay, we'll do this business but amongst the lot, you've got to realize one thing that there are suppliers who can be fair-weather friends. If business is good, we'll be with you, if business is bad, we're not with you. Now PCL has cultivated a partnership model for so many years. We've worked with companies and today we take pride in saying that we established suppliers when they were nothing and they've grown with us today. We've given them a single share of the business. We've given them a

large share of the business. They showed us a lot of responsibility that if they failed to deliver, they're in a problem. So cultivating a partnership model, working closely with the suppliers, and understanding each other's needs made them recognize the customer's importance. So all of that has been some of the practices that we've established with the suppliers. They've grown multi-fold. There's a distinction you need to make that unfortunately the shareholders are not putting money on the ground. Where will he go and find a shareholder or where will he find a customer? So we have absolute clarity in terms of what we owe to whom. I mean it's nice to say that without the customer, we would be nothing. I agree without the customer, we would not be there. But if the money was not there, who would put up the facilities, where would we get the customers from. If I go to the customer and say, look I'm going to put up 50 crores of plant, can you give me business? You'll say first put up the business, let me have a look at it, let me see the quality level and then I'll give you the business. It's as simple as that. People try and listen to different parts. Customer is the key undoubtedly but in this entire thing, we must not forget that the stakeholder is for us, the key to the entire story.

WHAT BENEFITS HAS YOUR COMPANY SEEN AS A DIRECT RESULT OF HAVING THIS STRATEGIC SUPPLIER RELATIONSHIP?

Take, for instance, we have 4 foundries. Between the 4 foundries, we probably have about 20 electric furnaces, big, small, large, etc. Now when we choose to start with one supplier who gave us good quality, met our requirements in terms of pricing, numbers, delivery time, and in terms of support, we establish a relationship with the company.

They gave us everything we wanted for which we had multiple choices. Among the multiple choices, this company came forward and met more than our requirements. What's the reward point for the term? The reward point for the term is as we expanded, we gave them the first right of refusal. End of the term we said, here's an opportunity and they grabbed it with all four hands and said okay, we'll take this up. So over a period of time, we established that they got the business. We were able to gain benefits of economy of scale, that we gave the order to the same company and you have to realize that once you have these many sets of automatically serviced spare parts, maintenance becomes easier unlike if I had at the end of the term sat the X, the Y the Z. So four varieties of furnaces in our company and once when one company goes down then none of us knows who to approach and how to approach because each furnace behaves and acts differently. So this is the same with capital equipment or this is the same with people who supply us raw material.

Progressively the same company has become a major success story in supplying sand in India. We've grown but we've made sure that those who stuck by us in the initial period, who gave us a lot of support during our initial difficult period were rewarded with large business as we grew. And I think that's the model that we continue to follow because it helps both the supplier as well as PCL. We both understand each other. So I think because we understood each other very well, there was no conflict and we continued to go forward.

HOW MANY SUPPLIERS DO YOU HAVE FOR YOUR BUSINESS THAT ARE KEY?

In capital equipment, I would say about 10 and in raw material, I would say about 15. There are



multiple other suppliers but we would not say that strategically in nature they're our partners. They were people for whom they give business with us which was not consistent. But to buy large for whatever we require in bulk or on a consistent level basis, we look at partners who understand our requirements and partners who are willing to stick through us in thick and thin. They are the most important. We're looking at suppliers who understand markets and are not driven by features. We're a derived demand. That too if you manufacture a car, you'll require a Camshaft but if you don't manufacture a car, you'll not require a Camshaft. If the situation deteriorates for some reason or the other, we expect our suppliers to say "Yeah, we recognize it and you're being very helpful and supportive. We also recognize that these are difficult times and we'll be with you in these times".

WHAT DO YOU THINK WOULD BE THE KEY BUSINESS MESSAGES THAT YOU WOULD WANT TO PROMOTE WITHIN THIS FEATURE?

I think the message is that we're an auto component supplier. Obviously, as I said all of us are derived demand. We're not individual suppliers. I think the key message that I want to give to a lot of people is first of all to diversify your product portfolio. Diversify your customer portfolio. For instance, our Precision Camshafts is not by chance but it is by desire which our pie chart reflects that none of our customers have a share of more than 16 percent globally. If you now look at a typical auto component supplier, it will be broken up into 3. The first would take 16, the second would take 13, the third would take 10 whereas we have approximately 25 customers but nobody takes more than 17 percent. We are spread between Korea, China, South America to

North America. Our customers are spread wide across the globe. Distribution is fairly diverse. Different types of customers need different applications hence we are a diversified product portfolio company but we own companies that do something besides Camshaft. That's what we have learned over a period of time. Let's say our core strength is Camshaft, You need to leverage the core strength that you have and that is why we've acquired companies that do products other than Camshafts. So we also wanted to diversify our product portfolio. I think another message I want to send is very clear. We're a highly balanced and driven organization. Although we're a technical company, we believe that it's important to actually see whether you're making profits or not and that is where I think most companies struggle in the auto component industry. The bottom line is simple. We're an auto component supplier and we are debt-free. That is a reflection of our conservative financial approach which has helped us. I think a conservative financial approach has got such a wide meaning that I can't tell you but to condense it and say, a conservative financial approach is extremely necessary for auto component suppliers. Typically they get highly leveraged. They go in a state of depending on one customer and recklessly invest heavily. One downturn and everything starts falling apart. So I think that's something that most auto components manufacturing units are cognizant of. I think one of the most important things is to ensure that we clearly are a systemic and profitable company. People neglect that a lot. There has to be a system and process for everything and the customers need to see it in that way, to define and develop customs, processes, protocols, and procedures for



everything so that it becomes independent of an individual. This is what the customers want to look at. What's there in that company that ensures that I get my product at the right time, at the right quality, and also at the right price. One of the most important things is why would a customer want to continue giving business to PCL. I think one more message I would like to send which the customer wants to see is that if you develop and make good quality, then 30 percent of the battle has been won. Honestly, the best technology means 50 percent of the battle won. Most important, 40 percent of the battle is won when you can demonstrate to the customers that you have the ability to invest for the future. So what does this even mean? Is the balance sheet strong? Do you have the money? Can you raise money? Let's assume that I'm supplying you with 10,000 Camshafts. Mr. Shah, your company is very good, 1000 Camshafts is fantastic, even the quality level is good, etc. So you got your act together. Within our company, we're thinking of giving you a business of 150,000 Camshafts. See I can't even think about this so the simple reason is the reason why it costs such a lot of investment. So how do you sell it? I've put up 10,000. My challenge is I can stretch it to 50. Can I go to 50? can I go to 100?. That's when you need a strong balance sheet, money, and the ability to raise finances. The customer actually does due diligence of your balance sheet and sees whether you're a partner for the present or whether you're the partner for the present and the future. Most companies don't look for a partner for the present. They say we want this company to be a partner with us for the next 15 years and this company to withstand the growth pressures that would apply.



Mr. Harishchandra Gupta - Chairman & MD

ROTO PUMPS

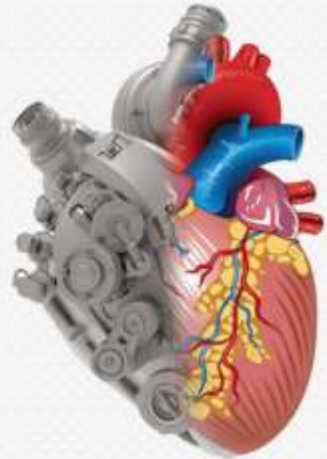
Compact Size - Commendable Performance

WE COMPETE WITH
ONLY ONE PUMP

Pumps Designed to deliver untiring performance persistently >>>

Industries we serve

Mining & Explosives Sugar Paint Wastewater Oil & Gas Paper Chemicals Food & Beverage Marine Biogas



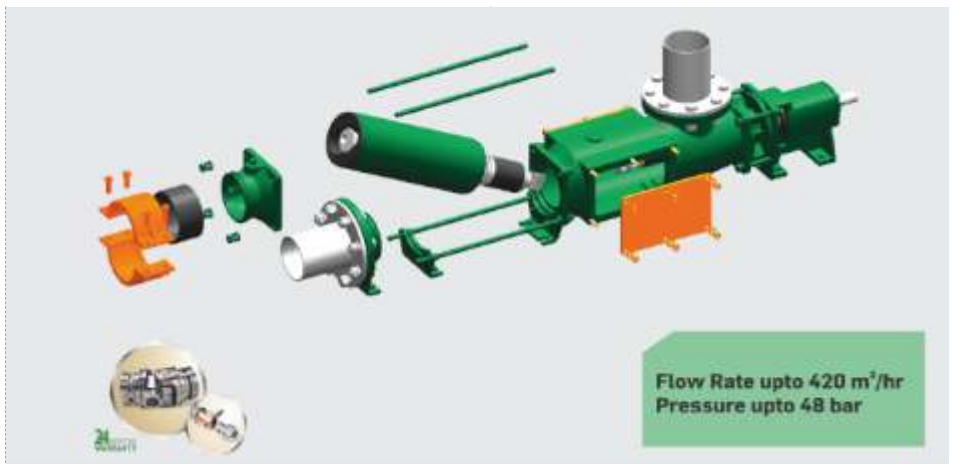
WHAT WERE THE OPPORTUNITIES YOU SAW FOR YOURSELF AND THE COMPANY WHEN YOU DECIDED TO TAKE ON THE ROLE?

When this company began earlier as a partnership firm way back in 1968, the founder invented a process of manufacturing a very specialized component of a pump that is now known as helical rotor pumps or progressive cavity pumps which he did on his own. The necessity of that was felt by him when he was running his coal mine because these types of pumps were being imported from England. At that time, he felt there was a problem as import duty was 200 percent, and getting a license for it was a nightmare. So he thought, why can't we manufacture these pumps in India and this is going back to the 1950s when that thought came to him and the environment around the total industrial change in India was hardly making any changes at that

time. So it was like challenging the best because nobody manufactured it and nobody knew this pump was developed by a French genius about 100 years back. Mono Pumps were the suppliers to India because it was this part of the colony that had a license from this French company. So my father was using these pumps in his own coal mine and had difficulties running it. I saw him in a very ugly state when I was a kid. He used to sleep with the Rotor under his bed and my mother would say, "What are you doing, I think you've gone mad and why do you keep having this thing on the bed" and then he kept it under the bed and used to look at it and do calculations. So what he was trying to do was to figure out a mathematical way of producing this component which is known as a Rotor. The Rotor is the heart of the pump and he did it by himself. That's how the enterprise was set up. In his initial years, these pumps were known only for mining as a mining pump and nobody believed

in the company. We were in Kanpur. This all started in Kanpur because nobody could believe that a company, that too a small company or a firm could do such a wonderful thing because everybody else was a licensee and nobody had a clue of how this complicated component was produced. So when he did that and we started, that's the time I joined. Even we started to look at supplies cares for mono pumps which were already existing but nobody believed, so we had to give them a couple of free samples to make them believe that "Yes, we can do it". So my job in the earlier part of my career was to focus on sales because we knew how to make it and having made that component, other parts were as simple as using items that could be easily copied and that's how we started selling first spares for mining pumps. Soon after that, we came out with the pump and we were the first in India to offer complete pumps to mining industries and that is how we were

lucky to get Marshall Sons & Co. (India) Ltd. They were the original im-porters of these pumps into India and they became our sole selling agents. In the past, exclusive to mining we started looking at other applications which Marshalls never bothered so I got lots of literature from them which was telling us that these pumps can be used for chemical processes, environment, excellent treatment, and many other appli-cations. Then we started working on spreading our wings in other industries and that's how gradually the industrial part of the business started growing and after this achievement of coal mines, we continued to be a prominent supplier. We also started in centrifugal pumps for mining industries and that gave a contribution to our founder because he was doing multi-stage centrifugal pumps for pumping the watering. So we were one of the most prominent suppliers and we were out of the three years larger than others but mind you, they were only doing centrifugal pumps whereas we were doing centrifugal pumps as well as progressive cavity pumps when nobody did progressive cavity pumps. The buyers later left our company, took the technology from us, and started doing these pumps so these were the pioneers. They are the market leaders and all the small companies these are from are called ex-Roto. This is a long journey of 55 years and you do seem to lose control over the others but we have again shifted our entire work from Kanpur to Noida. Then we normally set up a new MNC there which is now our corporate office excusing me for expose because, by quality standards, we could at-tain what was acceptable of the domestic market which was not open to import things and we realized that another two were viscous and



exposed, so the quality had to be up-graded. So a unit was set up in NSEZ in two to three zones that exclusively tackled the export market. That's how the journey in the export market was spread out in the early 90s and today we're quite confident. As you would've known it came with substantial market share, for instance in Australia, our market share is No. 2, and worldwide we are ranked No. 7. In this progressive cavity field, over a period of time, we have started overseas of mainly distribution companies and stocking facilities and that was started in 2001 in Australia followed by the U.K. in 2004. You know, presently this is how we ex-port to two thirds and one third is for the domestic market which we understand is going to become more important because the way the investments and infrastructures are taking place, they would continue to be an important market for us wherever we are marketing. We are into varied industries which are prominent. Since I'm talking globally, it will be wastewater. Wastewater has two sides - industrial wastewater and municipal wastewater. We are in both of these and the chemical and process which includes practically every industry in food and process.

WHAT ARE THE PLANS FOR THE COMPANY'S GROWTH IN THE MEDIUM TO LONG TERM, SAY 3 TO 5 YEARS TIME?

Up till now, it has been to increase our market share for all the markets we're present in and also the medium markets which we're present in ourselves. It's a small market of dealers, distributors and so the first objective is to establish product acceptance if they're in already demanding markets. We wanted to increase our market share in all these markets. Back then we were introducing above-the-ground pump applications, now we're going for something of an underground pump to bring the oil from underground. So that's one area where we are moving. It's been set up and that would also cater to the same facilities. It will cater to what is known as a Mud motor. The Mud motor is basical-ly a drilling technology where you use the same rotor and stator which is used there. Of course, it's made differently but the concept is the same. So we're going to do your pumping elements which are the rotor and stator for mud motors as well. We are going underground in terms of submersible pumps. So less submersible pumps in a big way and for that, we're setting up another manufacturing unit. That's how you know we are extending our wings and we continue to be in the core competency area which is the equipment for fluid handling. That's how we see ourselves growing very steadily. In 4 years our company value would be 500 Crores.

WHAT DO YOU BELIEVE SETS ROTO PUMPS APART FROM ITS COMPETITORS? HOW DO YOU DIFFERENTIATE YOUR COMPANY FROM ALL OTHER COMPANIES?

For some time, we had the position that we would provide you with a pump which you can buy especially in mining. They use to come for Roto Pump models. We had to taper up our business from mining because they would not value in quality instead they would buy the lowest one making the payments here very difficult. So gradually and steadily we moved away from mining, but we still do some business that's through agents. So the differentiator is that we realized everybody can announce that there are maybe 20 small companies that are supplying pumps. Hence we've now taken up the position of a solution provider rather than just supplying a pump which we refuse to supply if somebody says that supplier is Roto Pump. For such models we say, please let us know what you want. So we spend a lot of time and energy first knowing unless it's a replacement pump. If we've supplied a pump to someone and he wants to replace a pump, then of course. If it's just pump requirements, then a lot of timing is taken in understanding it first and that is quite a tricky job because people are used to giving specifications for centrifugal pumps which are the largest. 80 percent of the pumps are centrifugal pumps. Now nearly 70 percent of the pumps are centrifugal pumps. They gave the pumps without considering that this type of pump has got an elastomer or a rubber part that behaves differently. These pumps are not for clear water. For clear waters, the best pump is the centrifugal pump. So these pumps are quite difficult to handle fluids, viscous, fibers, and abrasives. It's very important to know exactly for what duty and what applications in very specific terms. We spend a considerable amount of time and despite the annoying response from the customers, we insist them to please let us know because we want to supply them a solution and not just sell them a pump. It has

helped greatly because we see the difference when we start understanding the requirement, particulars, selection, offering and then getting involved in most of the cases with the installation. Sometimes we customers don't put useless pumps because it's not so very well known. At least 30 years back they did not know how to use this pump, what pre-cautions to take, so we often get involved and we'll offer this service with a nominal price, to be involved in the installation, because if this pump is not installed properly, then it leads to problems. Technically we can say that okay, this is your fault, but that won't help others because the feeling is that Roto Pumps has failed, so we make extra efforts to focus on the installation and to ensure that the pumps are installed properly that too for the duty that they're bought for. This is again another problem because they buy pumps for X duty and then they put them for Y duty. This will not work as we put a disclaimer in our offer but then again the customers are customers, so we make sure that it is put to the duty and the duty is the same as what has been given in their inquiry, based on which we have selected the equipment for them. And hence the relationship of the end-user is established, which they often sell through couriers and contractors. We persuade them to let us know where the pumps are going because then the relationship is direct with the end-user and that is how we look after them and make sure we've provided the solution that works to their satisfaction. This has been a game-changer and I feel that for any equipment, people are looking for that turnkey kind of a thing to install, and as we're talking about it, not too much ahead, people would be anticipating that it will happen. People will give a contract for pumping and would say to you that the fluid has been pumped. So you go and install your equipment and after looking at that, you charge to the company. That's what they're interested in, that high duty in this process runs without any clashes. And if there's a need where the

failure occurs then they are the ones who will come and put another pump to make sure that it happens and that's how the companies are getting paid. This concept is here to catch on in India and eventually, it would.

WE WOULD LIKE TO UNDERSTAND HOW HAVE YOU ACTUALLY WORKED WITH YOUR VENDORS OVER THE YEARS TO FORM STABLE PARTNERSHIPS?

They're all stakeholders. Few vendors, suppliers, customers, employees, and also share-holders work for all statements of stakeholders. So we deal our vendors with stat and concede them with a very important partner for us to go ahead. Other than that we buy specialized things in terms of mechanical fields. Our most important thing for us is the past tense. So we had a very reliable period of time, and there was a bit of struggle. Before that, we left and continued to deal with these vendors who would supply us. We do standard steel casting. Lots of standard steel cast are in casting and also sometimes very specialized standard steel casting. So that's one side. Other than that it is still easy to bear. We use substandard steel, which is roll metal bear and we buy them at a fair price. For us, the quality is very important and at times we find ourselves paying a little higher than the cheapest. So that has been our consideration because we're committed to a world-class product. After our success story manufacturing operations of NSEZ units which were primarily for stores, we brought everything from Kanpur to Noida. We relocated and implanted the same quality standards for our domestic unit which was set up outside NSEZ. So the entire quality culture of the company was aligned to Global. That again meant having the liable supplier's vendors. We do most of the manufacturing in-house. Some child parts are manufactured from outside, otherwise, most of the critical components are manufactured in-house. Those vendors are very important for casting under because of the quality

and also timely delivery. This pump is not a mass-produced pump, it's almost a tailor-made pump. Having said that, they hire the pumps which move faster so you can afford to have a bigger batch and buy in large. Each and every pump is sold for its specific duty and that's where the concept of wading installation comes into place. We have to be very careful in choosing our vendors. At times we give a higher price and we're happy doing that because we're ensuring that the quality is not compromised.

ARE THERE ANY OTHER BENEFITS THAT YOUR COMPANY GETS AS A RESULT OF HAVING THIS STRATEGIC AND STRONG VENDOR RELATIONSHIP?

I think one of the things is that we become important to them so that they'll look after us on priority and we also pay them on time. So they value us as an important customer and they put their best input forward. Sometimes on the technical side, whenever we get some components manufactured, we go out and tell them how to do it differently in a more cost-effective manner so that they also save money and part of that money they save can be transferred to us by lowering their prices. So they're very happy doing it because the base of the company was discovering a manufacturing technology for manufacturing that very complicated part. So we are happy to share what we know with them so that they can do it in a more cost-effective manner. In our manufacturing setup, we have some very state-of-the-art, not only manufacturing but testing facility. That testing facility is of such an order that during the covid period, people didn't have to come to typically inspect the pump. They could inspect the pumps in a virtual manner. This is known as a start-up-based testing facility. We were the first to install such a thing. Maybe somebody has already done this with centrifugal pumps but we enable the customer to see this very pump and its readings through the meters in a digital meter as the customers couldn't come. We accept them by asking "why don't

you have an experience and see if you're satisfied, then you can wave the inspection or when there's no covid you can come. I think we've had good success with the Indian Oil company as a valued customer. So there was no way they could travel from Assam, Digboi, or some places. We have 7 express machines 5 express machines so we're a very well laid out manufacturing infrastructure.

TO GIVE ME AN INSIGHT INTO YOUR OPERATIONS, HOW MANY VENDORS DO YOU HAVE FOR YOUR BUSINESS THAT ARE KEY?

I would not know the common but I can just give you an example that we believe we should not have too many vendors because then we're not important to them and they won't give a focus to them. So our policy is to have the main vendor or at least two vendors. If something goes wrong with one vendor, we can switch over to another. In most of this, casting is a critical case. We would also have a geographical limitation. We got some casting vendors in Gujarat and some are in North India in NCR. So we don't want too many vendors. The policy is that we have two, maximum of three vendors for something that we buy in great quantity. We don't want that situation where they're offering the lowest. The fact that you buy in bulk, prompts these vendors to give us a good rate aiming the quality. So that's what we are. It is kind of a partnership that we have with them and they are very happy because we also pay them on time. We are one of the very good paymasters. So this is how they look at it. For the rubber pumps, the rubber comes from large companies. They have got agents in India that import in bulk and that is an important thing, otherwise for bearings and other things we don't really use too many as most of the pumps are close-coupled. We couldn't buy such a great deal as we were not using a bearing housing. What we buy most is casting and that next would be rolled steel, stainless steel, and rolled material. That would be number 1. Number 2 and other things would be, small bought out

components as we call them small bearings and things like that. So we established quality suppliers and we stick to them.

WHO PROVIDES YOU WITH CASTINGS WHICH ARE THEN PROVIDED FOR THE VENDORS? FOR EXAMPLE, TAKE RUBBER COMPONENTS. WHO PROVIDES YOU WITH THESE COMPONENTS?

The casting comes from various foundries. Some of them are located in Gujarat and some of them are located in North India. Most of the stainless steel castings come from Gujarat, and the chemical steel castings are of two types, one is investment steel casting that comes exclusively from Gujarat and then there's the casted stainless steel which is sand cast. That's a small part. This is how the casting is inspected and that's how it is there. Rolled stock is something which is available in the market and we insist that we buy it branded from a good source directly as far as possible. Rubber which is used on our rubber unit is a separate rubber component manufacturing unit where rubber and chemicals are bought. We buy it locally but it's against our order. Pumps with bearing housing require fewer and fewer bearings as pumps, so most of the pumps are directly coupled to the gear motor which has its own bearing. We don't buy too many bearings.

WHAT DO YOU THINK WOULD BE THE KEY BUSINESS MESSAGES THAT YOU WOULD LIKE TO SHARE WITH US?

For any engineering companies under which category we are broadly under, it is important to have a very good manufacturing infrastructure. It should be under your command because that's what's important to ensure that the quality is maintained and on-time delivery is there. And this sometimes means having a little bit more resources than what you would need because our business is a bit cyclic and sometimes all of sudden, there's more demand and big orders.

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Mrs. H.K. Joshi - Chairman & MD

SHIPPING CORPORATION OF INDIA

One does not work for Awards, Accolades and Recognition, I work with passion to bring change.

WHAT WERE THE OPPORTUNITIES YOU SAW FOR YOURSELF AND THE COMPANY WHEN YOU DECIDED TO TAKE ON THE ROLE?

I'd like to inform you that in February 2015 when I joined the Shipping Corporation of India, I joined the company in the capacity of Director Finance. So being at the helm of the affairs, actually leading the company from the front has been only about two years back. In September 2019, I was assigned the charge of chairperson and managing director of Shipping Corporation of India. So from 2019 onwards, I was driving the company but from 2015 to 2019 my job was limited to the Director Finance role. But that actually helped in building, strengthening, and preparing me for the ultimate job at the top because eventually, it's always the financial help and the commercial well-being of an entity that leads to its sustainability. We've been seeing this in 'n' number of companies that a lot of the good companies sometimes go into liquidation or bankruptcy simply because there have been some financial problems with them. I think I got a fantastic opportunity when I joined the company in 2015 to financially turn around the company. From 2010-2011 onwards, the company had been reporting financial losses for 3 consecutive years when I joined in 2015 but after that, the company had a financial turnaround. We

basically looked into a lot of fundamentals with respect to financial management, processes, systems, high levels of corporate governance, transparency and devised new systems so that you could have corporate government transparency and complete system and that always helps to strengthen the basic fundamentals of a company. Incidentally during that time, the company went through a lot of changes in terms of demonetization. The GST came in, and there were new accounting standards. Earlier we were following the gap. This was basically a phase of financial confirmation both outside as well as inside since what was happening outside was to impact the company inside as well. There was a lot of churning going on inside the company and that really helps the company to become financially robust. We have an immaculate speckless system of financial management in the company and I think that was the need of the hour. Building on that when I got to the helm of the affairs in September 2019, I started concentrating on the operations. Because earlier my portfolio was limited to finance, it would obviously be a different thing but both years helped me to clean up everything and it gave me a very sound foundation to start on. In September 2019 when I took over, we had the new 0.5 percent low sulfur fuel regulation coming in on 1st of January 2020 which were IMO guidelines and the company

seamlessly went into completely low sulfur IMO compliant company as of 1st of January 2020. So that was an operational achievement. On the 1st of January 2021, the IMO had determined a fiber risk compliance. In fact, in July 2020 itself, the company had already gotten the certification which was almost more than half a year in advance. That was the level of operational efficiency which had come into the company and what we should note. What is remarkable is that when we achieved a fiber risk management policy compliant with the IMO guidelines in July 2020, we were at the peak of the pandemic. So while there was a nationwide lockdown that had been announced in March 2020, it did not inhibit the company from continuing its operational excellence. We did not take it as an excuse that because there's a pandemic, we need some extension or we're not being able to meet the deadline. No! that hasn't happened in the company at all. In fact, we've broken all of our records of the past from there of a decade somewhere of 5 years but that has been the performance of the company in the pandemic and that gives me an immense sense of pride with my team that if we could achieve these levels of excellence in pandemic then I'm sure things are going to get much better when it normalizes. We're also now going into a complete installation of the last water treatment system which is again something that's required for



our sustainability as well as to show that we are an environmentally friendly company. We are already working on that and what I take pride in with respect to the last water treatment system installation which is currently ongoing is that the entire technical management of this is being done in-house. So it's not as if I've hired a consultant or somebody to help me. The installation of these systems is a highly technical thing because you're insisting that you need to identify the place so there's a lot of engineering which needs to be done. The complete design, change and all the technical work that is required are being done completely in-house. That's what I wanted to share with you about the operational excellence of the company and of course, if we're achieving all this, I don't need to tell you that when the nationwide lockdown was announced, the company did not shut down even for a single day. On 22nd and 23rd March when that was announced, we were just working as if nothing had happened.

WHAT ARE THE PLANS FOR THE

COMPANY'S GROWTH IN THE MEDIUM TO LONG TERM, SAY 3 TO 5 YEARS' TIME?

The company has to grow in terms of fund age and we're already working on that. Since we're in the service industry, if we have to render services then I have to have my fund age to be able to expand. So the expansion of fund age is a major plan and the company is working on it. They're already in the market. We floated some tenders so that's very much in the public domain with respect to the tonnage that we wanted to acquire so obviously the growth of the company happens with the growth of the tonnage which will give me fortunes for increasing the services. During the pandemic, we have also taken initiatives with respect to expanding the service range of the company. We started on the direct service between India and Mali. We are the first shipping line to call a particular port called Kundu Fushi. That port had never been touched by a shipping line earlier, so this is the initiative that the company has taken. We've got plans to open more shipping services. We've also

ventured into the inland waterways through our only own subsidiary which is inland and coastal shipping limited. So we're already operating two vessels on national waterways. We would want to expand to the Bangladesh protocol route and further on to the east. Inland waterway is a costly under-utilized sector. While the sector is currently not a profitable sector, one should set up the business. You do not expect to start reaping returns from Day 1 so there's always a gestation period but there's immense scope in this sector and we hoped to grow in this sector as well. We are shortly going to also start some more services.

WHAT DO YOU BELIEVE SETS SHIPPING CORPORATION OF INDIA APART FROM ITS COMPETITORS?

I wouldn't say that there's another Indian shipping company that is on par with Ship-ping Corporation of India because we're by far the largest Shipping company as of today and we're also the only completely diversified shipping company in India. There is no other Indian shipping company that has operations in all the segments of shipping. Whereas Shipping Corporation of India operates in all the segments of shipping which is the tanker segment, the bulk carrier segment, the technical and the offshore segment as well as in the container segment. As far as our competitors are concerned, I would really not know what my competitors are doing because I'm concentrating more on my business and ensuring that I excel. I'm competing with my own self to ensure that I raise the bar for the company higher and higher every day and that would automatically take care of my competitors. I don't need to see what they're doing because many times when you're trying to peep into the other, you're losing focus on your own self. So I think if you're doing your business

right and there's plenty of business for everybody in this world then you don't need to see what your competitor is doing. Just do your business right and that's what I've done and we've done pretty well with that policy. We have inherent advantages in terms of operational excellence and technical excellence. We are a very sound financial company. We also have extremely good standards of corporate governance. I think the fundamentals of a good company help my company to grow regardless of what my competitors are doing.

HOW HAVE YOU ACTUALLY WORKED WITH YOUR VENDORS OVER THE YEARS TO FORM STABLE PARTNER-SHIPS?

I would respond by saying that it's not only my vendors. I have also worked with all my stakeholders. Vendors are one part of the story and my customers are the other part of the story and there are plenty of other stakeholders who come in between the vendors, the company, and the customers. Business is all about networking, building relationships, building your own brand, and building your own goodwill which gives confidence to the vendors, your customers, and all your other stakeholders. They derive the comfort and the confidence from the stability of the company to be a business partner with me and for me, all my stakeholders are business partners. Without my vendors, I'd be nowhere, and even without my customers, I'd be nowhere. So I can never exist in a solo or isolation. I'm an integral part of this ecosystem and they're my business partners. It's extremely essential for me to not only have cordial relations but also build a warm and strong relationship with them as they're my partners in progress. That is the way I've built up my relationship and they have sustained me through this period.

I'm sure they're only going to strengthen as time goes along.

AS A GOVERNMENT COMPANY, HOW HAVE YOU MAINTAINED THE BRAND AND THE OPERATION OF THE COMPANY?

Like I just told you, it's very important to value, whether it be a vendor or a customer, you've got to value each one of them. Each one of them is important and you take care of them while you render quality service for us. Our tagline is that we're transporting goods and we're transforming lives. We actually follow that tagline not only in word but in deed actually. So we've got our spirit into that tagline of transporting goods and transforming lives. We take that very seriously.

WHAT BENEFIT HAS YOUR COMPANY SEEN AS A DIRECT RESULT OF HAVING THIS STRATEGIC VENDOR RELATIONSHIP?

It's a continuous flow. These are the important cogs of the wheel. Even if you remove one cog, you create an imbalance. You need to recognize the importance of each one of these. You can't say that only one cog has been contributed. It's a collective thing and I would not like to undermine it. At the back of all this, the most important stakeholder is my employees. It is the excellence of my team to keep all the cogs of this wheel well oiled and lubricated so we could move smoothly. These are all business strategies that one needs to know where to focus on and what's vital at one point in time may not continue to be vital at another point in time. You cannot have the same static business strategy, you need to keep evolving. At a point in time today something may become important because the environment is such and such. Tomorrow the environment is not static. We're in a volatile world so you need to keep

adapting your strategy depending upon what the environment is all about. So I cannot give you one single formula because it's always evolving.

WHAT DO YOU THINK WOULD BE THE KEY BUSINESS MESSAGES THAT YOU WOULD WANT TO BE PRO-MOTED WITHIN THIS FEATURE?

In terms of shipping, I would like to say that shipping is vital for the survival of mankind and when I'm talking about the survival of mankind, the economy comes at a much different level. If mankind would not survive, there would be an economic flourish because 90 percent of the goods by volume are transported by water shipping in terms of almost 70 percent of the value. That is the magnitude of what shipping can do to improve trade and economy but shipping is something that has not been truly recognized and is not getting its due importance. But it is absolutely vital for trade and economy and we need to ensure that the shipping gets its due importance like for example during the pandemic, the seafarers had a very bad time while they were sailing. They were unable to sign off the vessels, they were not able to go home for months because of this blockade, and you could not move from one place to another. So while they are our key workers because they were bringing all the goods to us, without these seafarers, we wouldn't get our daily necessities, anything that we have today. Whatever we find today, it will all have a linkage to shipping. So while they're also our key workers, I don't think every nation recognizes them as key workers. I would like to give this as a business message that our seafarers are the true key workers and they need to be recognized for the service they offer to mankind. That shipping is vital for business trade and the economy.



Mr. Chirag C Doshi - Managing Director & CEO

WALCHANDNAGAR INDUSTRIES

Pioneering Achievements in Indian Engineering Industry

WHAT WERE THE OPPORTUNITIES YOU SAW FOR YOURSELF AND THE COMPANY WHEN YOU DECIDED TO TAKE ON THE ROLE?

When I did my MBA in 2004, there was an opportunity for exploring how Walchandnagar could fulfill its potential as a company and expand more into the strategic sectors of India. We were already doing works for the IFRO, RDO, the ministry of defense, and the nuclear power cooperation and wanted to see how we could enhance that relationship and really take the company to the next level. So that was the inspiration behind a family member getting actively involved in the business again which we had not done for a while and as it played out over the last 14 years, there have been enough ups and downs but a lot of positives have come out of it and I think last year just before the pandemic on the 1st of April, our MD and CEO Mr. Pillai was retiring and he had served a good 8-10 years in the organization. The feeling was that instead of getting another external professional at a time when the company was going through a bit of a difficult period, I had to take over the day to day operations of the business and let the family sort of drive the business from the top for a few years till we return to the glory days if you want to call it. I expect that in the next 12-18 months when the turnaround is complete, ultimately we will look at bringing in professional

management in the future. So that was really the in-spiration that there was a huge opportunity and it was important for the family to put their face forward and be in charge for the moment if we may say so.

WHAT ARE THE PLANS FOR THE COMPANY'S GROWTH IN THE MEDIUM TO LONG TERM, SAY 3 TO 5 YEARS' TIME?

Some of the very strategic decisions were taken by the organization maybe five years ago when we started implementing our turnaround and we were going to look at our USP businesses where we have a huge competitive advantage and a relationship which is re-ally to focus on our manufacturing business, fabrication, design, and engineering businesses and focus on customers where we have built a relationship over the last 40 years that is in India's space program, India's defense program, India's nuclear power program, and India's missile program. To a certain extent, we are very good at product businesses which is our industrial and marine gearbox business, our process equipment especially those for crushing and grinding solutions, cement plants, and power plants which is really the focus of the business. We had a railways division and an ETC division in the past and we've decided to sort of close those and only focus on heavy fabrication, heavy manufacturing, and intricate design. We expect that all these sectors that we are in are poised

for. If you take programs like Atmanirbhar Bharat, Make in India, Design in India, and this whole India-centric movement that we have been seeing, of course, our company has been doing this for the last 50 years but even if what we see now, the vision of our honorable prime minister and his team. For the next 5-10 years it's going to be a golden period for the kind of work that we do, so I think we're going to narrow our focus down to certain industries, aerospace, defense, nuclear power, transmission for gearboxes, large crushing and grinding equipment and solutions. I expect that it will take care of most of our growth for the next 5-10 years.

ARE THERE ANY KEY AREAS THAT YOU WOULD LIKE TO FOCUS ON IN THE COMING 1 TO 1 AND A HALF YEARS?

Yes, over the next 18 months, the number one challenge that we face as an organization is to manage our debt in our company, so we definitely want to explore the reduction of debt. We are already in the process of doing that and we'll continue to do that. Cash flow management and the importance of generating cash from our balance sheet are going to be a very big focus for us. I think at the factory level, there are many areas of operational efficiency that we can focus on. I think that the last 1, 1 and a half years of covid as taught us how easy it is for us to use automation and digitization at a



plant level to really ramp up our execution capabilities so while we've done commendable work in the last 18 months, I think there's a lot of work that's left to be done and that it's going to be a big trust area for us to really use technology and IT to show that even heavy engineering and heavy manufacturing companies like ours can benefit from this migration to further automation. It's a big area for us. So these are the two areas that we focus on in a big way. I think we're blessed to have a very strong order book already with the company and so while the team is out there continuously marketing and focusing on generating business, efficient execution and cash flow management are the two things that this company will be focusing on in the next 18 months.

WHAT DO YOU BELIEVE SETS WALCHANDNAGAR APART FROM ITS COMPETITORS?

Since you talked to our operational excellence, I think one of the areas that we really do excel at is that we fundamentally have a deeply intelligent group of management along with both blue-collar and white-collar employees who work very well together. We have a very robust process of examining all processes at an extremely deep level. We do a lot of in-house R&D

and innovation, not just at a large product level or a machine level but even at an everyday process level where we've done a lot of work in-house without having to divulge our technologies and our secrets. Then it comes to the development of jigs and fixtures for the kind of equipment that we manufacture for our customers, so there's a very very deep competitive advantage we have from not just our competitors but any-one who wants to enter this space. I think people are a big positive for us. We have people who've been here three generations. Families that have worked in the company for three generations are as committed today to the cause as their grandfathers were and we have robust processes and systems that allow us to be able to maintain our high levels of quality and efficiency even if there's a change of man or woman at a worker level. So while we do depend on our people, the critical processes and systems of our company are non-people centric and I think finding the right balance there allows us to be agile. It allows us to be quick in decision making, to be on time for delivery, and obviously have the highest levels of quality. I think that it's these USPs that allow us to be different and stand out in our deliverables. That's really what I'm most proud of about

our organization.

HOW HAVE YOU WORKED WITH YOUR VENDORS OVER THE YEARS TO FORM STABLE PARTNERSHIPS?

In our kind of business, to some extent, we're a little bit advantaged from the fact that because we work with metals that are very rare and unique, a lot of our Indian vendors are unable to supply those materials so we usually get a lot of our materials free issue from our customers. So that takes care of a large challenge that we have but with regards to other types of vendors, there are two types of relationships we have that go very strong and deep. One is the relationship for the supply of really high-quality raw materials and in our case, the highest level of raw materials really stands out in plates, forgings, castings, welding electrodes, and weld consumables. I mean this constitutes the maximum buying that we do which is of the most critical nature to ensure the success of the highest quality of the equipment that we make. Historically over 20-30 years we've built relationships with some of the vendors and have maintained those relationships throughout. We're not a company that can go out there and change the vendor every year just because they offer us a better price. For having 20-30

reliable vendors, just so you know my actual vendor base is nearly 1000 active vendors. It's a very big vendor base but as a key core community, I think there would be about 50-80 vendors who take care of most of our critical requirements and these vendors have been with us for dec-ades. There's the raw materials supply vendor and then there's a community of subcontractors that we've created which are all around our Walchandnagar factory within a 5-15 km radius where these vendors, let's call them partners of manufacturing have been created again 30-50 years ago. They continue to work only with us and no one else be-cause we've literally raised them to reach certain levels of quality and efficiency which they could never have done on their own. So I think that's the kind of relationship that we like to build. It's a very family-oriented relationship where we want to treat them as if they're a part of the Walchand family and obviously there are some vendors who we work with very rarely. Those are not what we call true active vendors. So that's the way we look at our vendor for a setup and you know many people will tell you that they're also second or third-generation vendors to Walchandnagar and their grandfathers start-ed their relationship as a partner so it's a very open and family tight relationship.

ARE THERE ANY OTHER BENEFITS THAT YOU GET FROM HAVING THIS STRONG RELATIONSHIP WITH THESE VENDORS?

Yeah, of course, building these strategic relationships allows us to expand our output from the company much faster. It reduces our dependence especially on our jobs which are not of a very critical nature and don't require such high levels of quality. CNC machines and things like that allow us to really

ramp up our throughput much faster than we could. Also, we learn a lot from our vendors. I think part of the whole process is to look at how efficiently and creatively our vendors were able to execute certain jobs that we've given them. They help us in coming up with new, faster, and quicker processes for certain repeatable jobs so there's a symbiotic relationship where we also have to learn from them. It's not just that we give you a job then you give us back a job and we pay you money. I think there's a lot of learning that comes from this. There's a lot of interaction that happens between our vendors and my shop team. There's a cash flow benefit that comes when you can start working on moving towards more of an asset-light or an asset lighter model. We can never be an asset-light in our industry. But for an asset lighter model, the benefits that come from building relationships create USPs. These people can't work anywhere else for other competitors so it creates a bubble if you want to call it that, a bubble no one can penetrate and creates some sort of dependence on you from your customer and lastly I think there's a lot of learning that comes from this kind of strategic relationships. I haven't talked about the price benefit but as we make these vendors and their partners and business grow, they realize who has brought them to this level and they, of course, give us the benefit from a pricing perspective as well. I mean there have been situations where we have actually funded our vendors with capital expenditure and with capital equipment on a lease basis. I mean okay today in the last few years there are many areas in which microfinance can be availed for setting up new facilities but in the seventies, eighties, and the nineties, there was no such

opportunity for a lot of these vendors so we had to microfinance them and that has helped them become self-sufficient now as independent entities.

WHAT DO YOU THINK WOULD BE THE KEY BUSINESS MESSAGES THAT YOU WOULD WANT TO PROMOTE WITHIN THIS FEATURE?

The message that I would like to send out is that we're a company that has a huge legacy in this country. I think the new generation, I don't know Z or whatever alphabet is being used probably have no idea what this company and its founder Walchandnagar did for the industrialization of India. I mean today we hear terms like Atmanirbhar Bharat and things like that but people need to remember, recall and realize that when we were still ruled by the British in the early 1900s, it was this company and the founder of this company along with maybe one or two other industrialists that really set the groundwork for India to become self-sufficient post-independence. This company has continued its tradition of nation-building. In those days we used to do it through sugar plants, power plants, and maybe a train station here or there. Now our nation-building comes from go-ing to space, going underwater in submarines, be it a plane, ship, or building our own nuclear power plants or any kind of defense equipment that we need to protect our borders. We've evolved as an organization in continuing to be at the cutting edge of technology. We are second to none in this country if not in the world when it comes to our ability to manufacture and design and we will continue to explore new frontiers as long it fits into that box that we have laid for ourselves, that we are a patriotic nation-building organization that has been in existence of 112 years. That's the message.



Mr. Santosh Marathe - CCO

APOLLO HOSPITAL (NAVI MUMBAI)

Integrated care is a way to bring value back to the patient

COVID TAUGHT ME THAT AS A LEADER YOU HAVE TO BUILD A NETWORK OF TEAMS. YOU'VE GOT TO BE EXTREMELY VIGILANT AND READY TO MAKE CHANGES.

India has become a medical tourism destination because of the excellence of our facilities and our highly skilled healthcare professionals," he says. "Meanwhile, the level of healthcare technology has evolved and improved to the point where acute care, meaning when you're treated in the hospital, isn't the only option anymore."

Integrated care has become just as important. "Integrated care is a way to bring value back to the patient," he says. "How do I provide care after you go home? It's the kind of step-down and step-up care that's been invaluable during the pandemic."

The COVID-19 pandemic has raised the stakes for healthcare providers the world over. "The world is raging with COVID, and no single country has yet claimed they're fully recovered," he added. "We're still battling with it, so you need a pretty sustainable financial resource to manage throughout this period. You need to preserve your teams, and that means you need confidence – especially in private health care."

In order to keep all the plates spinning, that confidence has to extend to Apollo Hospital's extensive network of suppliers and partners. "Managing one of the first established hospitals in India has its own advantages," He says. "Which means our relationships with suppliers are long established." and this relationship so professional and transparent

It's not just one hospital they're supplying to, but many hospitals. That's how we try to get it as cost-effective as possible. We would never compromise on quality, because that's of absolute importance to us.

We're clear in communicating to those suppliers that it's never just about the price; it's important that we make sure supplies are of impeccable quality."

We're looking at post-care. We're continuing to develop our advanced and comprehensive oncology centre, and personally, I'm trying to create jobs and help the economy in my capacity as Leader. We play a huge part in the Indian healthcare system, and we have to keep our workforce going to maintain that. No lay-offs, no pay cuts, no reduction in the high quality patient care we provide."

It's a strategy that's closely aligned with Apollo Hospital Navi Mumbai's core values: integrity, empathy, teamwork, excellence and, above all, patients first. "We only exist because of our patients," he says. "You need to collaborate with multiple partners – whether it's doctors, staff, suppliers or even the patients. And when patients form positive relationships and trust their healthcare providers, they become more engaged."

It's a testament to the continuous improvement that we have achieved," says Santosh Marathe. "We like doing this because, in the end, patients are the most important factor. When they come to the hospital, what they want is to receive an accurate diagnosis and treatment delivered in the shortest time.

The fact is, nobody wants to stay in hospital unnecessarily. We continue to focus on delivering an accurate diagnosis and treatment in the shortest possible time."

"From the start, it was a compelling opportunity, because it's such a great platform

Having spent so long within healthcare sector over 17+ years at some of Asia's largest healthcare providers, he's developed an expertise in the field. But his interest was first piqued when he was still working

This is no doubt why he is so deeply engaged with the Hospital. "From the start, it was a compelling opportunity, because it's such a great platform," he says.

"Having been established decades ago, Apollo Hospitals Navi Mumbai is a Asia platform that provides quality, affordable and accessible health care to the people of India. I realized the platform can rapidly be expanded to serve many more people across Asia."

6 values patience, discipline, competence, trustworthiness, selflessness and kindness. "Unlike industries such as banking and finance, the healthcare sector is very sensitive and critical

"What I love about health care is that every day is different and we have a real impact on people's lives. for example we spent time looking at sanitary ware for the hospital, but by the afternoon I was meeting with doctors to discuss the technology of the future. This diversity keeps me going."

SPEED AUTOMOBILES



The Hypercar: An Exhibit Of Speed And Substance at the Petersen Automotive Museum, Los Angeles

The Petersen Automotive Museum has announced a new exhibit that explores the world of Hypercars, the fastest and most exclusive cars money can buy, beginning on December 4, 2021, in Los Angeles.

Over the next 18 months, the exhibit entitled Hypercars: The Allure of the Extreme will rotate up to 30 vehicles that highlight what Hypercars look and feel like, defining how they captivate the highest end, global automotive community. The two-part exhibit also the meaning of Hypercars with



a display of vehicles, including the Bugatti Veyron, the Devel Sixteen, the Hennessey Venom F5 and the Pagani Huayra Hermes Edition

In addition, vehicles already confirmed to be on display will include the Aria FXE concept, Bugatti Veyron 16.4, Caparo T1, Devel Sixteen, Ferrari LaFerrari Aperta, Hennessey Venom F5 (Design Model), Koenigsegg Agera RS Final Edition, Laraki Sahara, McLaren Speedtail, NIO EP9, Delage D12, Pagani Huayra Hermes Edition, RAESR Tachyon Speed and Rimac Concept One. It will also include two motorcycles that fit the description, including the Lotus C-01 and Aston Martin AMB 001. The Czinger 21C will make occasional, brief appearances, and will be on display for the last two weeks of December 2021.

"Hypercars are glimpses of the luxury future today," said Petersen Automotive Museum Executive Director Terry L. Karges. "With this

exhibit, we want to depict what a Hypercar is, while allowing guests the opportunity to view some of the rarest and most luxurious available."

The Petersen Museum defines a Hypercar as a vehicle that exists at the highest echelon of performance, technological advancement, price, and rarity. The exhibit showcases projects from both well-known, and less known brands that have fascinated audiences and potential buyers with their performance, cutting-edge technological breakthroughs, and as always, their splendid beauty.

Hypercars: The Allure of the Extreme will be located in the Bruce Meyer Family Gallery and the museum lobby. The exhibit will be shown in two successive portions; the first will be on display from December 4, 2021 to September 22, 2022; the second on September 17, 2022, and leave on May 14, 2023. www.petersen.org.

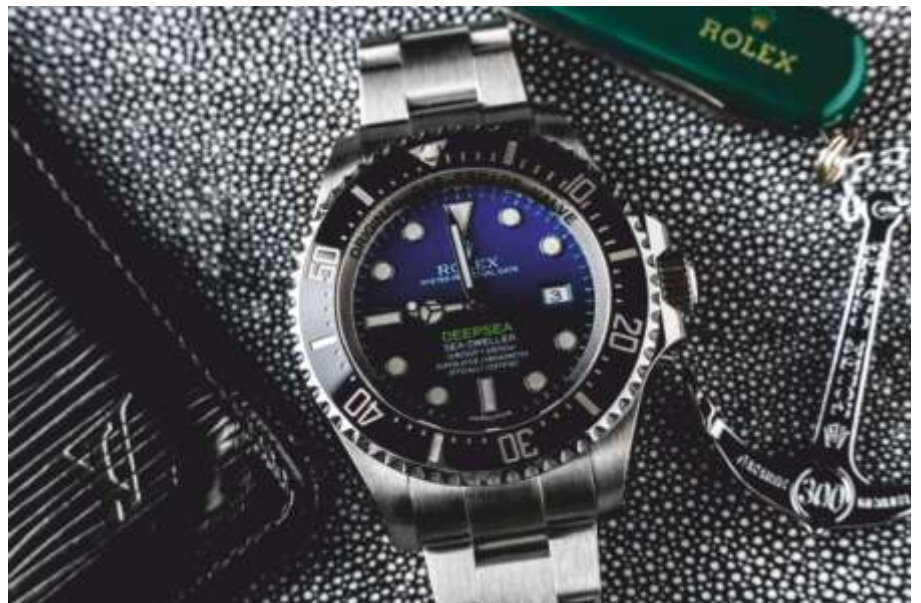
FASHION



THE HOLIDAYS ARE RIGHT AROUND THE CORNER AND A LUXURY WATCH ALWAYS MAKES THE PERFECT GIFT!

This year's hottest new tech gadgets will already be outdated by the time summer arrives, but a high-quality timepiece is built to last a lifetime. Fantastic luxury watches exist at nearly every possible price point, and regardless of whether your budget is under a grand or tens of thousands of dollars, you will still be able to get a great timepiece for that special person this holiday season.

Watches are often viewed as extensions of our personalities and the type of wristwatch that a person chooses to wear can often tell you a lot about them. Unless you know the person incredibly well (and are also familiar with the other watches they have their collection), it is generally best to play it safe and give them a timepiece that you know will effortlessly find a place in



their daily life and wardrobe. While these models are often not the most colorful or unusual, they are timeless classics that will always have a meaningful place in a person's collection, regardless of their personal style or where their watch collecting journey may take them.

Below are some of our top picks for luxury watches to give as gifts this holiday season, and we have an

option at every possible price point, from under \$1,000 to well into the five-figure range.

BOB'S WATCHES

Oris Big Crown ProPilot – Under \$1,000

Oris is often the first name that comes to mind whenever discussing budget-friendly, Swiss-made luxury watches, and the company has a rich history that dates all the way



back to 1904. The brand's two dive watch collections (the Divers Sixty-Five and Aquis) are usually the go-to recommendations for those that are new to the brand; however, if you are shopping for a gift this year, we think you should consider a watch from the Big Crown ProPilot series due to their ultra-versatile styling and clean, classic design.

Tudor Black Bay – \$1,000 To \$3,000

As Rolex's more affordable sibling company, Tudor is no stranger to making high-end timepieces that seriously deliver at their relatively modest price point. Despite the brand's notoriety, a budget of just a few thousand dollars is all that is required to grant you access to many of its most famous models when shopping on the pre-owned market, and it should come as no surprise to see a Tudor Black Bay make an appearance on this year's holiday gift guide.

Omega Speedmaster – \$3,000 To \$5,000

From sponsoring the Olympics to being the official timepiece of

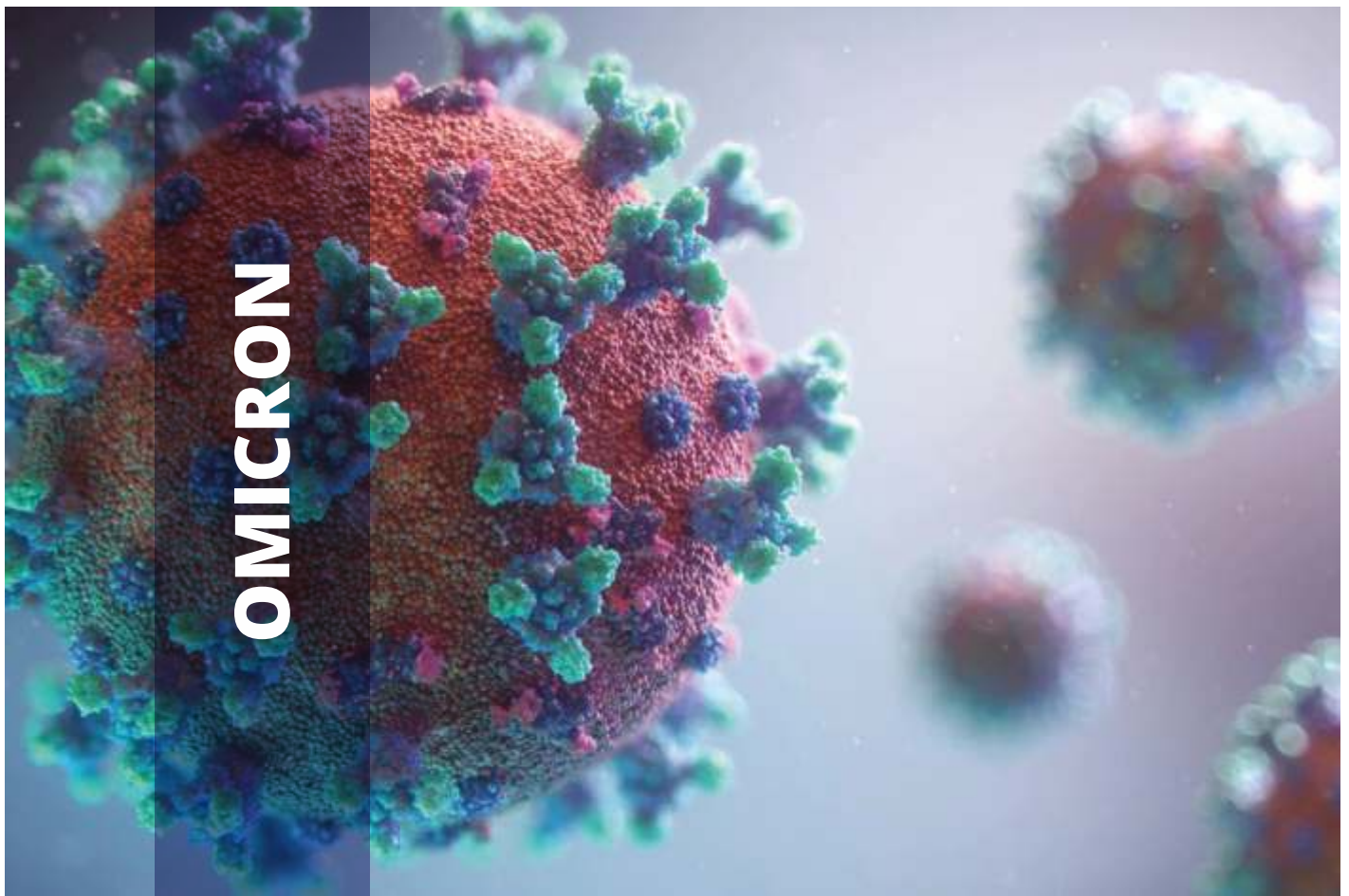
James Bond, Omega is easily one of the world's most famous luxury watch manufacturers and it has a history of producing excellent watches that dates all the way back to 1848. Omega's catalog is vast, and there is truly a bit of something for everyone to be found within it. However, the single watch that comes to most people's minds wherever discussing the brand is the classic Omega Speedmaster Moonwatch.

Rolex Submariner – \$5,000 To \$10,000

Rolex is easily the world's most famous luxury watch brand and

arguably one of the most famous companies that has ever existed. The incredible popularity of Rolex's various stainless steel sports watches have resulted in them becoming impossible to purchase at a retail level, and available examples now trade hands on the pre-owned market for values that are in excess of twice or even three times their original brand-new retail price. With that in mind, probably the single most famous sports watch of all time is the Rolex Submariner, and it is an obligatory addition to any watch-themed holiday gift guide.





CLASSIFICATION OF OMICRON (B.1.1.529): SARS-COV-2 VARIANT OF CONCERN

The Technical Advisory Group on SARS-CoV-2 Virus Evolution (TAG-VE) is an independent group of experts that periodically monitors and evaluates the evolution of SARS-CoV-2 and assesses if specific mutations and combinations of mutations alter the behaviour of the virus. The TAG-VE was convened on 26 November 2021 to assess the SARS-CoV-2 variant: B.1.1.529.

The B.1.1.529 variant was first reported to WHO from South Africa on 24 November 2021. The epidemiological situation in South Africa has been characterized by three distinct peaks in reported cases, the latest of which was predominantly the Delta variant. In recent weeks, infections have increased steeply, coinciding with

the detection of B.1.1.529 variant. The first known confirmed B.1.1.529 infection was from a specimen collected on 9 November 2021.

This variant has a large number of mutations, some of which are concerning. Preliminary evidence suggests an increased risk of reinfection with this variant, as compared to other VOCs. The number of cases of this variant appears to be increasing in almost all provinces in South Africa. Current SARS-CoV-2 PCR diagnostics continue to detect this variant. Several labs have indicated that for one widely used PCR test, one of the three target genes is not detected (called S gene dropout or S gene target failure) and this test can therefore be used as marker for

this variant, pending sequencing confirmation. Using this approach, this variant has been detected at faster rates than previous surges in infection, suggesting that this variant may have a growth advantage.

There are a number of studies underway and the TAG-VE will continue to evaluate this variant. WHO will communicate new findings with Member States and to the public as needed.

Based on the evidence presented indicative of a detrimental change in COVID-19 epidemiology, the TAG-VE has advised WHO that this variant should be designated as a VOC, and the WHO has designated B.1.1.529 as a VOC, named Omicron.

As such, countries are asked to do the following:

- enhance surveillance and sequencing efforts to better understand circulating SARS-CoV-2 variants.
- submit complete genome sequences and associated metadata to a publicly available database, such as GISAID.
- report initial cases/clusters associated with VOC infection to WHO through the IHR mechanism.
- where capacity exists and in coordination with the international community, perform field investigations and laboratory assessments to improve understanding of the potential impacts of the VOC on COVID-19 epidemiology, severity, effectiveness of public health and social measures, diagnostic methods, immune responses, antibody neutralization, or other relevant

characteristics.

Individuals are reminded to take measures to reduce their risk of COVID-19, including proven public health and social measures such as wearing well-fitting masks, hand hygiene, physical distancing, improving ventilation of indoor spaces, avoiding crowded spaces, and getting vaccinated.

For reference, WHO has working definitions for SARS-CoV-2 Variant of Interest (VOI) and Variant of Concern (VOC).

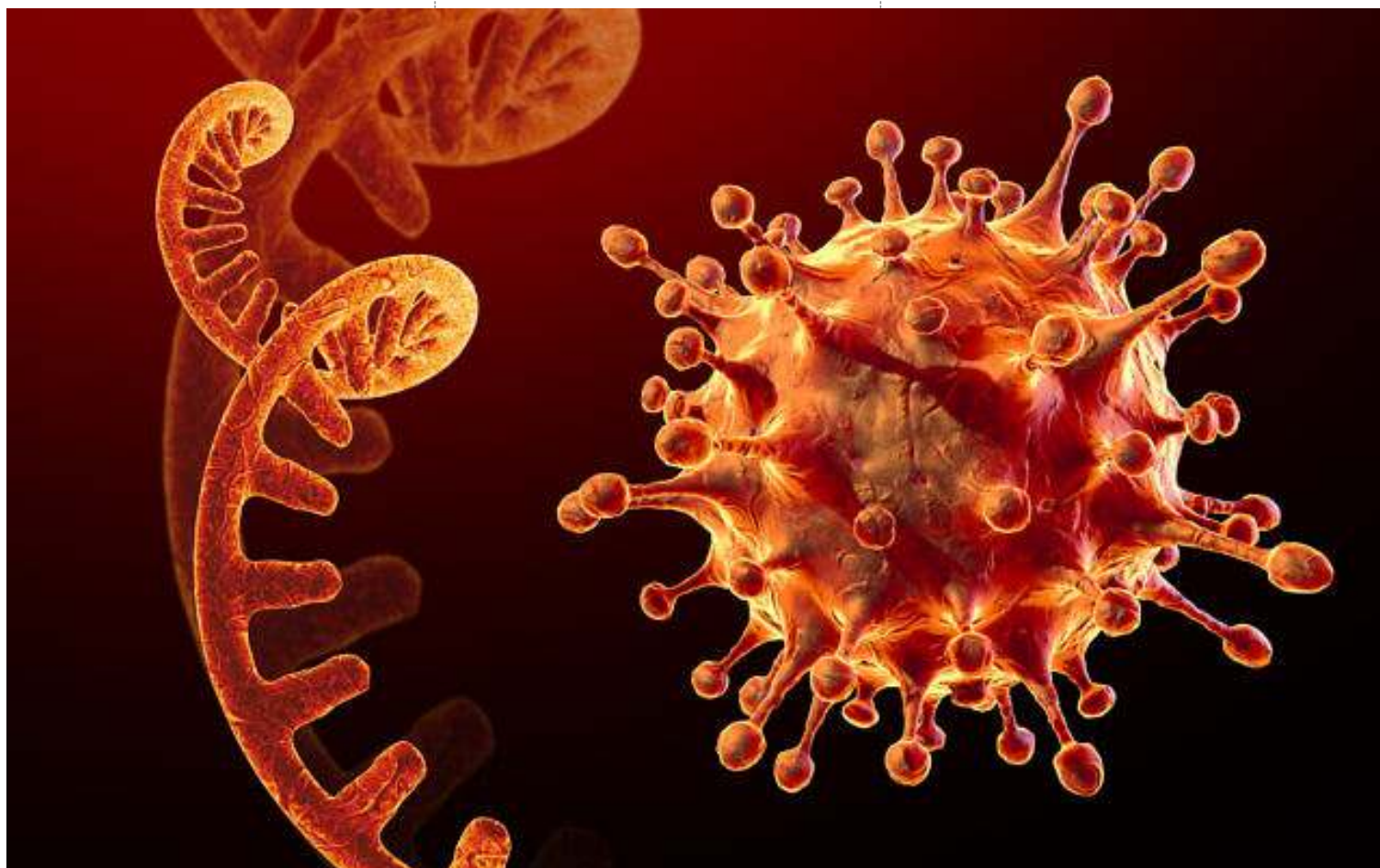
A SARS-COV-2 VOI IS A SARS-COV-2 VARIANT:

- with genetic changes that are predicted or known to affect virus characteristics such as transmissibility, disease severity, immune escape, diagnostic or therapeutic escape; AND
- that has been identified as causing significant community transmission or multiple COVID-

19 clusters, in multiple countries with increasing relative prevalence alongside increasing number of cases over time, or other apparent epidemiological impacts to suggest an emerging risk to global public health.

A SARS-CoV-2 VOC is a SARS-CoV-2 variant that meets the definition of a VOI (see above) and, through a comparative assessment, has been demonstrated to be associated with one or more of the following changes at a degree of global public health significance:

- increase in transmissibility or detrimental change in COVID-19 epidemiology; OR
- increase in virulence or change in clinical disease presentation; OR
- decrease in effectiveness of public health and social measures or available diagnostics, vaccines, therapeutics



LUXURY VACATION



(credit: courtesy of Emerald Maldives Resort & Spa)

EMERALD FAARUFUSHI RESORT & SPA TO DEBUT IN 2022 IN THE MALDIVES

The Emerald Collection, the luxury resort group behind Emerald Maldives Resort & Spa, will soon double in size with the upcoming Emerald Faarufushi Resort & Spa. Set to open May 1, 2022 on a seven-hectare private island in the Raa Atoll, it is just a 25-minute boat ride from Emerald Maldives Resort & Spa.

“We are thrilled to announce the acquisition and launch of our second property in the Maldivian archipelago, Emerald Faarufushi Resort & Spa,” said Aldo Scarapicchia, Partner and Managing Director of The Emerald Collection. “The acquisition of Emerald Faarufushi Resort & Spa is an exciting stage in our growth as a collection of distinctive luxury tropical resorts and consolidates our brand’s international presence which spans from the Maldives to Zanzibar.”

The lusciously green island is home to a beautiful house reef and encapsulates barefoot elegance at its finest while staying true to the thriving Maldivian environment that surrounds the resort, from offerings, design and more. Incorporating natural elements of stone and wood, its minimalistic and sophisticated design provides a platform for seclusion and privacy in order to create the ultimate bucket-list experience for all travelers.

The resort will feature 80 villas split into six different categories (Beach Villas (10), Family Villas with Pool (10), Beach Villas with Pool (17), Water Villa with Pool (39), Superior Water Villa with Pool (3) and one Presidential Villa beautifully located on the pristine beach) along with five restaurants and two bars to choose from. Leading the culinary charge is its signature Italian restaurant, Mediterraneo and

Eclipse Bar, both located on the resort’s scenic jetty.

Also located at the resort is Emerald Spa, a haven of holistic wellness; a state-of-the-art wellness facility hidden amongst the lush vegetation of palm trees. Elevated amongst the rising palm trees, the spa features eight treatment rooms each designed with an oval roof. There is a steam room, a manicure and pedicure corner, a yoga pavilion, plunge pools, a spa boutique, and an immersive relaxation area – the perfect spot for forest bathing. The spa menu draws from Balinese tradition and extensive fitness and water sports options. Guests can make use of the tennis court or paddle court in the marina and an air-conditioned Gym & Sports Center with Technogym equipment, or partake at the five-star Diving Center, where guests can achieve the coveted PADI license.

THE ENDLESS WINTER



5 RESORTS FOR THE FINEST ALPINE ADVENTURES & APRÈS SKI

Winter is here, which means for some of us that the mountains are calling. With access to some of the most celebrated slopes in North America, plus luxury packages covering private jet travel and a “First Tracks” program, these five resorts from the Canadian Rockies and California’s Martis Valley to the mountains of Colorado will leave skiers and snowboarders spoiled for choice. The holidays are fast approaching so there is plenty of festive programming on offer too – from a Menorah lighting ceremony and winter solstice yoga sessions to Christmas and New Year’s Eve dinners.

Whether looking to go big with a heli-skiing trip or mellow-paced activities like a guided snowshoe tour appeals, the options for adventures are endless. Off the mountain, chic après spots and seasonally inspired spa treatments also feature. Fairmont Banff

Springs, Canada

Built in the style of a Scottish castle by the Canadian Pacific Railway and opened in 1888, Fairmont Banff Springs is considered the birthplace of tourism in the Canadian Rockies. The grand dame hotel has provided

a sophisticated resort experience to visitors for more than a century and is as famous for its storybook alpine views as its facilities, highlights of which include the Willow Stream Spa. Nestled inside Banff National Park, about an hour and a half from



Calgary, the region is known for its Champagne powder, so as one might imagine, the skiing is world-class with shuttles running guests to the nearby resorts of Lake Louise, Mt. Norquay, and Sunshine Village. Available through April 30, 2022, the hotel's Luxury Ski Package includes accommodation, daily a la carté breakfast, self-parking, shuttle service, and two tri-area ski passes per room. Meanwhile, a solid lineup of curated winter experiences provides access to the great outdoors with options ranging from a snowshoe under the stars tour (s'mores included) and snowmobiling to ice fishing and sleigh rides. For the thrill-seekers, there's a full-day ice climbing excursion. Dinner or late-night drinks in the outdoor 360° Dome should make for a memorable experience; while new this season, a Winter Wonderland will feature a skating rink and private fire pits, plus drinks and snacks served from a rustic cabin.

The Ritz-Carlton, Lake Tahoe

Enjoying a prime mid-mountain position on Northstar Resort, guests will be spoiled with unrivaled ski-in, ski-out access at The Ritz-Carlton, Lake Tahoe. The cozy mountain retreat meets high-end hotel boasts



a slope-side spa and handsomely appointed rooms and marble bathrooms that feature fireplaces and oversized soaking tubs, respectively. A dedicated mountain concierge can help take care of everything from scheduling ski lessons and equipment rentals to getting kids set up with classes at the Burton Snowboard Academy. Couples or families can hang up the skis and jump on a full moon snowshoe hike or schedule a scenic helicopter tour over the Lake Tahoe Basin. And guests will be spoiled for choice when it comes to holiday

events - advance reservations are required for the Christmas and New Year's Eve Dinners at fine dining restaurant Manzanita – while après-ski hangouts range from the Whiskey & Waffles Cabin to the Champagne & Caviar



GLOBAL WELLNESS



AMID PANDEMIC DISRUPTIONS

The Global Wellness Economy Stands at \$4.4 Trillion but is Forecast to Reach \$7 Trillion by 2025.

The new Global Wellness Institute research, the most in-depth in its history, reveals that the wellness market grew to a record \$4.9 trillion in 2019 and then fell to \$4.4 trillion in the pandemic year of 2020. But with consumer values shifting underway, the future of the wellness market is predicted to grow 10% annually through 2025. The report was unveiled at the Global Wellness Summit, held in Boston from November 30-December 3rd, 2021. We were there.

The research report, “The Global Wellness Economy: Looking Beyond

Covid” provides new global market data on the overall wellness economy and for each of its sectors. The highlights are below:

The GWI last measured the wellness industry at \$4.3 trillion in 2017, and the new research reveals that it grew to historic levels in the



two years before the pandemic, reaching \$4.9 trillion in 2019. But with massive economic shocks from COVID-19, the global wellness economy fell 11%, to \$4.4 trillion, in 2020.

However, with the pandemic ushering major shifts in values for consumers, governments, and the medical world, where prevention and wellness take on greater importance, the GWI predicts that the wellness market will return to pre-pandemic levels in 2021 (\$5 trillion), and will grow at an impressive 10% annual pace through 2025, when it will reach \$7 trillion.

Unsurprisingly, sectors requiring a physical presence and/or full immersion for the actual experience, including physical activity, wellness tourism, spas, and thermal/mineral springs, saw the biggest pandemic declines—while healthy eating/nutrition/weight loss, wellness real estate, mental wellness, and the public health/prevention/personalized medicine category all showed strong pandemic growth. For the first time, the research breaks down the total wellness economy for each global region.

The Asia-Pacific was one of the fastest-growing wellness markets from 2017 to 2019 (8.1% growth), and it also shrank the least during the pandemic (-6.4%).

Plenary Meeting: Global Wellness Institute Presentation

Conversely, North America was the fastest-growing wellness region from 2017 to 2019 (8.4%), but among the hardest hit by the pandemic (-13.4%). Asia-Pacific had the largest wellness market in 2020 (\$1.5 trillion), followed by North America (\$1.3 trillion), and Europe (\$1.1 trillion). Per capita spending



on wellness is significantly higher in North America (\$3,567) and Europe (\$1,236) than in other global regions.

The growth projections for wellness markets 2020-2025 are defined by numbers referring to the 2020 market, the 2025 market, and average annual growth rate

Wellness Tourism: \$436 billion—\$1.1 trillion—+21%

Thermal/Mineral Springs: \$39 billion—\$90 billion—+18%

Spas: \$69 billion—\$150.5 billion—+17%

Wellness Real Estate: \$275 billion—\$580 billion—+16%

Physical Activity: \$738 billion—\$1.2 trillion—+10.2%

Mental Wellness: \$131 billion—\$210 billion—+9.8%

Personal Care & Beauty: \$955 billion—\$1.4 trillion—+8%

Traditional & Complementary Medicine: \$413 billion—\$583 billion—+7%

Healthy Eating, Nutrition & Weight Loss: \$945.5 billion—\$1.2 trillion—+5%

Public Health, Prevention & Personalized Medicine: \$375 billion—\$478 billion—+5%

Workplace Wellness: \$48.5 billion—\$58 billion—+4%

Wellness Market Snapshots and Takeaways:

Wellness Tourism (pandemic loser, future winner): Grew 8% annually from 2017 to 2019 (reaching \$720 billion) and then took a major hit in 2020. The market shrunk -39.5% to \$436 billion, while wellness trips dropped from 936 million to 601 million. The impressive 21% annual growth rate projected for wellness tourism through 2025 reflects new traveler values (a quest for nature, sustainability, mental wellness) as well as a period of rapid recovery from pent-up demand in 2021 and 2022.

Thermal/Mineral Springs (pandemic loser, future winner): One of the fastest-growing wellness markets from 2017 to 2019, with revenues rising from \$56 billion to \$64 billion (6.8% annual growth). Hit hard by the pandemic, revenues fell -39% in 2020, shrinking the market to \$39 billion. There are now 35,099 hot springs establishments across 130

countries. The downturn is temporary: Very strong 18% annual growth is expected through 2025, with 140-plus new projects in the pipeline.

Spas (pandemic loser, future winner): From 2017 to 2019, the spa industry was growing at a fast 8.7% annual rate and reached \$111 billion in revenues across 165,714 spas—with a big jump in hotel/resort spas (from 48,248 to 60,873). The high-touch industry was hit hard in 2020: Revenues fell by -39% (to \$69 billion) and spa establishments dropped to 160,100 (with a loss of over 4,000 day spas). But the industry is expected to recover quickly, with the market growing 17% annually through 2025, and more than doubling revenues (to \$150.5 billion.)

Wellness Real Estate (pandemic and future winner): With COVID-19 dramatically accelerating the understanding of the role that the built environment and our homes play in our physical and mental health, the wellness real estate market was the #1 growth-leader both before and during the pandemic: The market grew from \$148.5 billion in 2017 to \$225 billion in 2019 to \$275 billion in 2020 (22% annual growth). Wellness residential projects (either built or in the pipeline) skyrocketed from 740 in 2018 to over 2,300 today. Wellness real estate will continue its growth surge: The market will double to \$580 billion from 2020 to 2025 (16% annual growth.)

Physical Activity (pandemic loser, future winner): This six-sector market grew 5% from 201

Workplace Wellness (pandemic loser, future winner, with a difference): This segment grew 4.6% annually from 2017 to



2019—reaching a market high of \$52.2 billion—but then shrank 7% in 2020, to \$48.5 billion. Companies are recognizing that a compartmentalized, programmatic approach to employee wellbeing is not particularly effective in tackling the rising challenges of stress, work-life balance, and mental health, so many are shifting to more meaningful, holistic approaches encompassing everything from changing company culture to focusing on the built environment. These expenditures cannot be measured as “workplace wellness,” so expenditures may decline even as the focus on employee wellbeing actually expands. Even so, the market is pegged to grow 4% annually through 2025, reaching \$58.4 billion.

GLOBAL WELLNESS INSTITUTE

“The wellness economy will grow to \$7 trillion in 2025, because the forces that have been driving it remain as powerful as ever: an expanding global middle class, an aging population, and rising chronic disease,” said Katherine Johnston, GWI senior research fellow.

“But the pandemic,” she continues, “has brought new shifts and a global values reset:

Wellness now means far more than a facial or spin class. It has now an emerging, growing focus on mental wellbeing, importance of work-life balance, social justice,



environmental sustainability, the built environment, and public health. These drivers will underpin the recovery of the wellness economy; they will also shift consumer, policy and healthcare spending in new directions.”

AIRPODS



APPLE AIRPODS (3RD GENERATION) REVIEW

A SLEEKER APPEARANCE, SPATIAL AUDIO AND MORE.

It is half a decade since the original AirPods arrived on the scene and shook up the Bluetooth earbud status quo. Initially ridiculed for their long-stemmed design, it wasn't long before they were ubiquitous – the standout leaders in a nascent, burgeoning market. They offered a design, form factor and user experience that captured the public imagination, and gave the technology almost instant appeal.

Over the past half decade, Apple's line has changed infrequently. In March 2019, a second-generation product was introduced, which added the H1 chip for hands-free "Hey Siri" and improved wireless functionality, a better battery, and an optional wireless charging case. In the same year, the company added a premium product to the

line: the AirPods Pro. The model adds active noise cancellation (plus a transparency mode), a standard wireless charging case, and silicone tips — the latter especially warmly welcomed by Apple headphone devotees.

The recently released AirPods (3rd generation) model feature a swish new design, the addition of spatial audio, sweat and water resistance, and comes with a MagSafe charging case (all shared features with the Pros). Furthermore, they get an additional hour of battery life on the buds, and six extra hours with the case, bringing the totals up to six and 30 hours of life, respectively. At £169 (\$179), they fall in between the Pros (£239/\$249) and the second-gen (£119/\$129). The updated standard AirPods have further blurred the lines between the two SKUs. Indeed, the shorter stems and longer charge time bring the design language far more in line with the Pros.

The three key differentiators between the models are active noise cancelling, silicone ear tips, and, naturally, pricing. The Pros are still priced at a premium and are the company's best earbuds, along with being one of the best premium earbuds on the market. Nevertheless, there are several compelling reasons to buy the new AirPods.

AirPods (3rd generation) are a notable step up from their predecessors in terms of features and sound quality. The new buds offer greater contouring and hence a more comfortable fit than their predecessors. I have average-sized ears, and the moulded plastic tips fit perfectly – in fact, I prefer them to the silicone tips, which I tend to find can inadvertently be pulled off. For those with larger or much smaller ears, however, having different-sized, removable tips is a lifesaver. The seal those tips provide

also create passive noise-cancelling through a physical seal that effectively keeps in more audio frequencies and blocks out ambient noise. As a central London dweller, much of my life is spent immersed in street noise — and, for that matter, a constant barrage of construction. The Pros' active and passive noise cancellation can make a huge difference when faced with the constant cacophony of city life: sirens, revved up engines and building work. On the flip side, there are reasons to appreciate this from a situational awareness standpoint.

Spatial audio has been a strong feature of AirPods Pro and now it's available here. It provides a surround-sound effect for movie soundtracks from the iPad, for example. Spatial audio is wonderful, and it even comes with dynamic head tracking. If you watch a movie on the iPad and you turn your head, the earbuds adjust the output so that the audio is locked to where the screen is, which makes the overall effect more realistic. It's also compatible with Dolby Atmos, unlike the previous model. There's also adaptive EQ, which uses the AirPods' inward-facing microphones, along with computational audio, to tune the sound output to the shape of your ear, to ensure the best sound for your hearing.

Another welcome update to the AirPods (3rd generation) is the wireless charging. You can pop the

case on a MagSafe or standard Qi charger. Spatial audio is another nifty feature. On a FaceTime call with multiple parties, their voices are assigned locations based on where their boxes sit on the call. The effect is also novel in an app like Apple Music, which adjusts sound based on your location to the source (your phone, tablet, etc.) almost as if it were the speaker.

Unlike previous AirPods, the new model has an IP rating, IPX4, meaning that they are water-resistant enough to deal easily with sweat or precipitation. The shorter stalks on these AirPods are controlled from a touch-sensitive panel, as with AirPods Pro: squeezing the stalk changes the track, for instance.

The new AirPods also get support for the Find My feature, which adds a Bluetooth beacon-style layer onto the existing functionality. That makes it easier to find the individual buds in close quarters. The feature recently came into its own when it helped me track down my AirPods, which had both slipped down under the divan during the night. Finding them was the easy part. Recovering them required my husband's superhuman strength and a lot of mattress manoeuvring.

Furthermore, AirPods (3rd generation) have certain features that even AirPods Pro do not, such as a new skin-detection sensor. AirPods have, since their inception, have been able to recognise when an earbud is

removed and to automatically pause what you're listening to until you put it back. Apple has now enhanced this feature to stop the AirPods thinking they're in your ears when they're in, say, a bag.

In conclusion, AirPods (3rd generation) are outstandingly good. In terms of sound quality alone, the new AirPods are fantastic: yielding full-bodied sound and plenty of power. Apple has tuned the sound subtly and authentically. Vocals are clear, mid-ranges bouncy. The new design is a big improvement, and the extra battery life a big bonus. As ever, your best bet is generally buying a pair of earbuds from the same company that made your phone. The pairing was certainly stronger on iOS, but the AirPods also worked well with my husband's Android devices. Noise-cancelling apart, the audio is very nearly as strong as on AirPods Pro, and the £70/\$70 difference between them and the Pros is worth considering. If you're not fussed about active noise cancelling and/or prefer modelled plastic tips, then the choice is easy.

Apple AirPods third-generation Technical Specifications

Price £169/\$179 | Dimensions Earbuds: 1.21 x 0.72 x 0.76 inches (30.79 x 18.26 x 19.21mm), Case 1.83 x 2.14 x 0.84 inches (46.4 x 54.4 x 21.38mm) | Weight: Earbuds 0.15 ounces (4.28g), Case 1.34 ounces (37.91g) | Water-resistance IPX4





POWERED THREE SPIRIT FINALLY BREAKS INTO US MARKET

Since launching in 2018, UK-based Three Spirit amassed a cult following that led their plant-based, non-alcoholic spirits to being listed in some of the world's best bars, including Soho House and Connaught, and sold in luxury retailers like Harvey Nichols and Burford Garden Centre. And now, they've finally broken into the US market.

Three Spirits was developed in response to people looking for exciting alternatives to alcoholic drinks that gave them the same celebratory feelings without the need for actual alcohol. The brand worked with some of the best bartenders, herbalists, and plant scientists to get the final range, which combines 11 herbs and plants with naturally blissful qualities. Vegan and gluten-free, the social elixirs are hand-crafted with high-grade extracts, active plants, and adaptogens grown by cultivators.

"Our mission is pure pleasure innovation. This is not an imitation of an alcoholic drink. It is something that stands out on its own, enhances cocktails and creates a new option," explains co-founder Dash Lilley, Head Alchemist. "We achieve this through an obsessive focus on maximizing the functional potency of our drinks, carefully extracting the active compounds from the highest-grade, ethically-sourced plants we can get our hands on. Our process, Botanical Alchemy, is complex, delicate and takes time – maceration, fermentation, distillation, reverse osmosis, freeze-drying, ultrasonic extraction – you name it, we're pioneering it."

Three Spirits broke into the US in January 2021 and since then the direct-to-consumer product has sold out twice, with thousands on the waiting list. They've also gotten a lot of attention from the prestigious San Francisco World Spirits Competition, where they took home Double Gold for

Nightcap and Silver for both their Livener and Social Elixir spirits.

The brand has three products (\$39 each) that each offer something very different:

- Fierce, fiery and fruity in flavor, Livener is a vibrant, powerful drink designed to liven the senses and perk you up. Notes of red berries, bright aromatics and heat compliment the tannic touches from guayusa and guava leaf. It contains a natural, friendly caffeine found in guayusa, along with L-Theanine from green tea and ginseng.
- Dark, bittersweet and curious, Social Elixir, is the ultimate social companion and mood elevator. Natural, blissful feeling with lion's mane mushroom, yerba mate, tulsi, cacao and damiana. Bright, dry spiced on the nose lead to rich, complex dark apple and cacao notes. It's a full-bodied and bittersweet drink with a curious savory bite.



OVER 9M IN TOP CRYPTO TRADED ON BINANCE | WHALE MOVEMENT SPOTTED

Bitcoin along with the majority of the markets has once again dipped in price falling from a little over \$50K down to around \$47K before trading sideways at \$48K. With that, massive whale movement was once again spotted on Binance.

Massive Whale Movement on Bitcoin

Whales usually have the power to move smaller cryptocurrencies but when it comes to Bitcoin, it takes a lot of buying power to actually move the currency significantly. Of course, the move in BTC can be attributed to not just one whale but rather multiple whales in play.

Just recently, CoinTrendz.com on Twitter has spotted five significant whale trades in the last 24 hours for the BTC/USDT pair with a total of \$5 million (during the time of the tweet). Although this is just extremely small compared to BTC's market cap of over \$900 billion USD, this significant trade might

have had an impact on the price of Bitcoin.

BTC Price Performance Bullish and Bearish

The cryptocurrency was up by around \$50.5K to \$51K before dropping down to a little over \$47K. To expand, however, the price of BTC has been able to recover and is now trading at around \$48.5K.

That number, however, has since been added on as seen on a message on Telegram by CoinTrendz.com.

Here are the Top Whale Trades on Binance in the Last 24 Hours

- 1.46 million USD worth of BTC was traded 12 hours ago
- 999.99 thousand USD worth of BTC was traded 11 hours ago
- 1.01 million USD worth of BTC was traded 16 hours ago
- 885.65 thousand USD worth of BTC was traded 8 hours ago

\$9 Million Total of BTC in Whale Transactions

Although the amount of transactions initially tweeted out was at \$5 million, the significant whale movements in Bitcoin over the last 24 hours have resulted in over \$9 million total. To add, these transactions result in almost 0.001% of Bitcoin's total market cap.

What \$9 Million Could do for Smaller Market Caps

This might not seem like a huge number, however, the significant 0.001% wasn't the only transactions with Bitcoin that happened in the last 24 hours. To explain, this amount would have a significant impact on cryptocurrencies aside from BTC with a smaller market cap.

With smaller cryptocurrencies like the Binance coin or BNB, \$9 million would total almost 10% of the cryptocurrency's market cap meaning a movement that big could trigger either almost a 10% price drop or price spike.



WORK MEETINGS IN THE METAVERSE?

BILL GATES PREDICTS VIRTUAL MEETINGS WILL MOVE TO THE METAVERSE 2 TO 3 YEARS FROM NOW

Microsoft co-founder and billionaire Bill Gates said virtual meetings would predictably move to the metaverse within two to three years.

WORK MEETINGS IN THE METAVERSE?

The metaverse might be here sooner than we think. Microsoft co-founder and billionaire Bill Gates predict most workers will conduct virtual meetings through the metaverse within two to three years.

With how metaverse dominated the talks in every social media site, soon workplace meetings may shift in the digital space. Gates agreed to this, and in his year-in-review post that was published on his personal website, he wrote, "I predict most virtual meetings will move from 2D camera image grids - which I call

the "Hollywood Squares model," although I know that probably dates me - to the metaverse, a 3D space with digital avatars."

Regardless of his prediction, Gates still thinks that the time range he expected will extend because there will be interventions in establishing





live out their dreams or everyday experiences digitally.

In fact, virtual meetings today are already similar to the metaverse, with only a photo of you representing your presence in a meeting. However, the experience lacks immersion because there are no other technologies besides a computer or phone screen.

Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg emphasizes the importance of the metaverse as an alternative to the modern internet in the next five to ten years. He predicts that key components of the metaverse will become mainstream by then.

Earlier this year, Meta (formerly known as Facebook) announced Horizon Workrooms, a VR app where people can meet in virtual workrooms. Multiple companies have expressed interest in gaining a stake.

Though, Bill Gates' Microsoft won't be late to the party as they have their own virtual space. The company makes holograms and creates mixed and extended reality applications, and it owns Minecraft, a kid-friendly game that's evolved into its virtual universe.

In addition, another kid-friendly platform, Roblox, has partnered with brands such as Ralph Lauren, Gucci, and Vans to bring unique merchandise to the metaverse.

a workplace in the metaverse. In his opinion, many people would have a hard time adopting metaverse meetings because they lack the tools to immerse themselves at full capacities, such as virtual reality goggles.

However, he expressed optimism for advances in three-dimensional avatars and spatial audio technology that can help users feel more connected electronically.

The billionaire believes that several changes and efforts have to be

made first. Yet, he acknowledged that technology is already at its peak as it brings people together.

"There's still some work to do, but we're approaching a threshold where the technology begins to truly replicate the experience of being together in the office," said Gates.

WHAT IS THE METAVERSE?

A metaverse, or virtual universe, combines virtual reality, augmented reality, and video to allow users to





PARTNER NETWORK

TECH MAHINDRA

ACHIEVES PREMIER CONSULTING PARTNER STATUS IN THE AWS PARTNER NETWORK

Tech Mahindra, a leading provider of digital transformation, consulting, and business re-engineering services and solutions, announced today its new Premier Consulting Partner status in the AWS Partner Network (APN). This tier is awarded through successful demonstration of competence on multiple fronts such as technical proficiency, customer satisfaction, thought leadership, and revenue recognition.

This recognition reiterates Tech Mahindra's position as a dominant leader in cloud and reflects its differentiated industry expertise

and notable success in helping customers design, architect, build, migrate, and manage their workloads on AWS. With this collaboration, Tech Mahindra joins a select group of 125 Partners who have achieved the Premier status so far out of the total 6,000+ global AWS Partners.

Sudhir Nair, Senior Vice President and Global Head, Infrastructure and Cloud Services at Tech Mahindra said, "Tech Mahindra has been at the forefront of delivering human-centric experiences and enabling seamless digital transformation for customers across the globe by leveraging innovative technological solutions. Being recognized as Premier Consulting Partner in the AWS Partner Network is a

testament to our commitment towards the same."

As an AWS Premier Consulting Partner and AWS Managed Service Provider (MSP) Partner, Tech Mahindra holds certified qualifications like Migration Consulting Competency, Well Architected Framework (WAF), and AWS Solution Provider. This allows Tech Mahindra to help customers become agile, lean, and build reliable platforms and applications on AWS. Over the last five years, Tech Mahindra has built a strong AWS Practice with over 1700+ AWS-accredited associates, including more than 1,000+ AWS-certified engineers and architects across various streams of transformation and a dedicated AWS CoE (Centre of Excellence).



Tech Mahindra believes in DigitALL philosophy for comprehensive Business Transformation. Digital technologies catalyze the transformations – they humanize businesses by helping them think, sense, connect, communicate, secure and act better than before. As part of NXT.NOWTM framework, which aims to enhance ‘Human Centric Experience’, Tech Mahindra focuses on investing in emerging technologies and solutions that enable digital transformation and meet the evolving needs of the customer.

About Tech Mahindra

Tech Mahindra offers innovative and customer -centric digital experiences, enabling enterprises, associates and the society to Rise. We are a USD 5.1 billion organization with 141,100+ professionals across 90 countries helping 1123 global customers, including Fortune 500 companies.

We are focused on leveraging next-generation technologies including 5G, Blockchain, Cybersecurity, Artificial Intelligence, and more, to enable end-to-end digital transformation for global customers. Tech Mahindra is one of the fastest growing brands and amongst the top 15 IT service providers globally. Tech Mahindra has consistently emerged as a leader in sustainability and is recognized amongst the ‘2021 Global 100 Most sustainable corporations in the World’ by Corporate Knights. With the NXT.NOWTM framework, Tech Mahindra aims to enhance ‘Human Centric Experience’ for our ecosystem and drive collaborative disruption with synergies arising from a robust portfolio of companies. Tech Mahindra aims at delivering tomorrow’s experiences today and believes that the ‘Future is Now’.

We are part of the Mahindra Group, founded in 1945, one of the largest and most admired multinational federation of companies with 260,000 employees in over 100 countries. It enjoys a leadership position in farm equipment, utility vehicles, information technology and financial services in India and is the world’s largest tractor company by volume. It has a strong presence in renewable energy, agriculture, logistics, hospitality and real estate. The Mahindra Group has a clear focus on leading ESG globally, enabling rural prosperity and enhancing urban living, with a goal to drive positive change in the lives of communities and stakeholders to enable them to Rise.



WATCH IN ASIA IN 2021

Over the past year, startups all over Asia have thrived in their respective fields. With the pandemic changing the way we live, people have been looking for innovation.

Startups answer this need, addressing often-overlooked problems in modern, creative ways. And their methods are paying off.

In the first half of 2021, startups in Asia saw \$61.9 billion in funding. This was a 15% rise from its figures last year.

Let's check out the top seven Asian startups to watch out for in 2021.

1. SPENMO

Spenco is a Singapore-based fintech company founded just last year, in 2020. They are currently

doing business in Singapore, Indonesia, and Vietnam.

They specialize in providing financial solutions for small and medium-sized businesses. These solutions include vendor and supplier payments and payroll management.

Their most well-known services are local and international fund transfers and corporate cards. They also offer seamless expense claims and credit card to cash conversions.

Each of their clients processes around 500 to 9,000 payables per month. Spenco's system helps significantly in easing each company's bookkeeping workload.

This September, Spenco secured one of the most extensive Series A

funding rounds to date. Insight Partners, a New York-based firm, led the investment round.

The fundraiser secured \$34 million for the company. This increase in resources will allow them to expand operations across Southeast Asia.

2. ULA

Founded in 2020, Ula is a marketplace app that focuses on helping small retailers. Its services focus on mom-and-pop shops and neighbourhood kiosks.

The founder drew inspiration from neighbourhood retail in India, where he came from. These types of stores are also common in Indonesia, where Ula is now based. The app aims to streamline and modernize the supply chain for these smaller shops.

These stores and kiosks are a large part of day-to-day commerce in Indonesia. But, most of them haven't yet adopted modern technology in their operations. They still rely most on physical travel for payments and filling their inventory.

This is the issue Ula seeks to solve. As of May 2021, they already have over 30,000 small businesses signed onto the app.

Last September, Amazon founder Jeff Bezos made his first investment in the company.

3. BEATO

BeatO is a healthcare platform that helps users manage chronic diseases like diabetes. Since its founding in 2015 and app launch in 2016, it has acquired half a million app installs.

In its five years, the company has built a comprehensive selection of services. Its users can find resources for every aspect of chronic disease management.

They have doctors and health coaches on call. You can also utilize their app to order medicines and book lab tests. Their online shop offers a wide selection of food, supplements, and monitoring devices.

In 2020, the company got ISO certified. And this year, they have expanded their operations from India to Singapore.

4. LOGIVAN

Founded in 2017, Logivan is a Vietnam-based logistics and transportation startup.

The company offers a technological solution to Vietnam's fragmented highway

transportation network. It connects businesses to reliable trucks to streamline their logistics processes.

Through digitizing the process, businesses and truckers alike can save on logistics costs. Logivan ensures to maximize each truck's trip, minimizing the waste of resources.

Currently, they can connect a network of over 60,000 truck drivers to various companies. Some of their company clients include Coca-Cola, Wilmar, and Olam, among others.

As of this year, the company is worth \$7.9 million. Their key backers include Insignia Ventures Partners, K3 Ventures, and VinaCapital.

5. AGRIST

Japan is currently facing a shortage of farming labour. It is a critical industry, especially on food security. But, not enough young farmers are replacing their older counterparts.

Agrist is a Japan-based farming venture that seeks to address this problem. Founded in 2019, the company develops AI-driven robot technology to assist farmers.

Their robot harvesters aim to supplement this limited labour supply. In turn, the technology will help sustain Japan's agriculture in the years to come.

Currently, Agrist has raised over \$4.5 million in capital. They charge \$15,000 for a three-year lease plus 10% of the harvester's profits.

6. CLASSUM

Classum is a South Korean education platform for teachers and corporate trainers. It simplifies the process by putting all necessary tools in one place.

It unifies chat, video, and learning tools, with a user experience much like social media sites. The familiar format makes it easier for educators to engage with learners.

The platform also analyzes lesson data for the user. They collect information on participation rates, top content, and member performance.

As of April this year, Classum has raised \$6.7 million in three funding rounds. Some of their prominent investors are Korean gaming companies Pearl Abyss and Smilegate.

7. DAYTA AI

Founded in 2018, Dayta AI is a Hong Kong-based software company. They specialize in retail analytics based on video captured through surveillance cameras.

Through surveillance footage from retail stores, Dayta's software analyzes consumer behaviour. It collects information about peak hours, customer demographics, and store traffic.

The information their AI gleans can help businesses pinpoint specific strengths and weaknesses. This allows retailers to adjust their strategies to improve sales and customer experience.

Dayta AI has currently raised \$3 million. This amount includes funds from the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology (HKUST) and ParticleX.

These seven companies only show a mere fraction of the actual number of Asian startups on the rise. Even an active pandemic cannot halt human innovation



VACUUM SLEEPING BAGS SEEK TO PREVENT VISION LOSS FROM MARS MISSIONS

In this handout image provided by NASA, the first high-resolution, color image to be sent back by the Hazard Cameras (Hazcams) on the underside of NASA's Perseverance Mars rover after its landing in the area known as Jezero crater on February 18, 2021 on the planet Mars. A key objective for Perseverance's mission on Mars is astrobiology, including the search for signs of ancient microbial life. The rover will characterize the planet's geology and past climate, paving the way for human exploration of the Red Planet, and be the first mission to collect and cache Martian rock and regolith.

NASA ASTRONAUTS AND VISION PROBLEMS

Although NASA has been sending astronauts to the International Space Station or the ISS to stay for a couple of months for years now, the solution to their vision problems after going back to Earth remains to be seen.

As per the report by GenSide UK, the strange effect of staying in space for a prolonged time was first discovered way back in 2005.

During that time, a NASA astronaut, John Phillips, flew back to Earth with a significant decrease in his eyesight after staying in the ISS for six months. His vision went from 20/20



to 20/100 after his space mission.

After which, there have been a couple of theories that have emerged from the incident.

However, the reason behind it has only been unraveled after research, which was led by a professor of radiology and biomedical engineering at the University of Miami, Noam Alperin, investigated it.

The study went on to figure out that the eyesight problem from staying in outer space after a few months is caused by a change in the chemistry of the brain of a person.

To be precise, the research found out that the cerebrospinal fluid in some parts of the brain of astronauts increases, which then results in significant vision loss.

The additional fluid in the brain

specifically causes the eyeballs of humans to permanently flatten, which end up in vision problems, or worse cases, blindness.

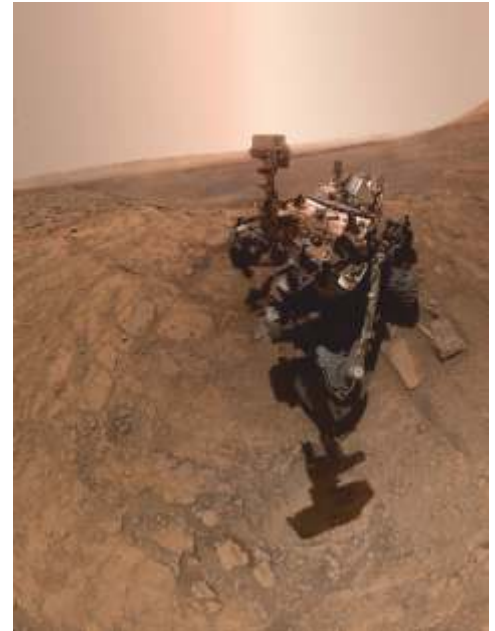
NASA Astronauts' Vacuum Sleeping Bags

With all that said, a group of scientists from the Southwestern Medical Center of the University of Texas or UT focused to study the issue that NASA astronauts are facing with regards to their eyesight.

As per the report by Republic World, the United States space agency reached out to UT to unfold a solution to the raging eyesight problem amongst their astronauts.

It comes as NASA is also looking forward to bringing back humans to the Moon, and soon after, the Red Planet.

The study of the scientist-led them into developing a vacuum sleeping bag that could prevent the flattening of the eyeballs of those who will stay in space for a couple of months.



(credits: courtesy Google images)





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